

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF
MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 24 SEPTEMBER 2026



THIRTY-TWO SEATS IS NINE MORE THAN A VETO NEEDS, AND IT LASTS FIVE YEARS (P3)

SINGAPORE

Your October power bill is priced off April's oil. The September spike arrives in January

THE MACRO DESK

The ten-year rose fifteen basis points and the breakeven moved two. Thirteen of them were real

THE LONG READ

A state that can name the 135,000 people it stopped, and cannot count the ill to within two orders of magnitude

THIS ISSUE · NO. 112

Contents

- p3–4** The World — a veto lost in July by the party that would have needed it in September

p5 Singapore — the tariff is set by a window that shut in June

p6 The Atelier — the cheaper merino tee has the finer wool

p7 Technology — a right nobody examined, enforced five years later

p8 The Home Lab — the card’s score describes a file you are not running

p9 The Kit — it wins at long context by outlasting the card, not beating it

p10 The Good Life — photographs arrive after the order book has shut

p11 Screen & Sound — the twelve-track album that was final until Friday
- p12–13** The Family Desk — regulations laid this year, in force in spring 2027

p14 The Macro Desk — thirteen of the fifteen basis points were real

p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — sourdough: the wild yeast is mostly shop yeast

p18 Fitness — twelve minutes, measured on seven days of wear

p19–20 The Diary — two things close before October does; five openings, two judgeable

p21–23 The Long Read — Kazakhstan: exclusion by database

p24 The Last Word — a sewer acts on water; a register acts on a person

FROM THE DESK

“The past is never dead. It’s not even past.”

William Faulkner, *Requiem for a Nun* (1951)

Every instrument in this issue was set by a window that had already closed, and read faithfully anyway.

THE STRIP · AT WEDNESDAY’S CLOSE

US 10-year (par)	5.11%	▼ +15bp
US 10-year real	2.76%	▼ +13bp
US 2-year (par)	4.85%	▼ +14bp
Brent (front)	\$98.36	▲ +3.09%
Gold (Dec /oz)	\$4,322.70	▼ -1.23%
Bitcoin	\$84,326	▼ -2.16%
VWRA (All-World)	193.62	▼ -0.69%
AGGU (global agg)	5.747	▼ -0.30%
USD/SGD	1.2793	▲ +0.39%

Wednesday 23 September. Treasury figures are the par curve read from the raw daily file, not the market close; the full chain runs on **p14**.¹ Not advice.

WHAT THIS ISSUE KEEPS FINDING

The window shuts before the price is read. A Singapore power bill charges April’s oil in October, and the September spike will arrive in January (**p5**). A German utility model filed in 2020, never examined, published last October, bars an American firm this month (**p7**). A Kazakh debtors’ register decides who may place a bet (**p21**).

And the instrument is not the thing. Thirteen of fifteen basis points were the price of real money, not of inflation (**p14**). A benchmark on a model card describes a file 41.7 per cent worse at predicting text (**p8**). Twelve minutes a week is a hazard ratio read off seven days of wear (**p18**). And the wild yeast in the jar is mostly the yeast in the packet (**p15**).

SOURCES 1 Par and real yields read from the US Treasury’s own raw daily CSV for 23 September 2026 — not the rendered table, which carries an extra column and shifts every maturity one place. Other levels as set out with their origins on **p14**. Gold is the December future, not a spot fix, and is not a record: it sits roughly 22 per cent below its 52-week high. Brent is the front-month future; dated Brent ran \$15.64 above it on the last common print.

SCHWERIN · A FIREWALL, COUNTED

The party that cannot govern now owns the constitution

Thirty-two seats is three short of a majority and nine more than a veto needs. The CDU, which killed the fix for exactly this in July, no longer holds a single seat in the chamber.

Read the constitution before the result. Article 56 of Mecklenburg-Vorpommern's Landesverfassung requires two-thirds of the Landtag's members to amend it — 48 of 71. Anything above 23 seats is therefore a permanent veto.¹ On Sunday the AfD took **388,026** second votes, **38.22 per cent**, and **32 seats**.²

Article 52 does the same work on the bench. The state constitutional court is seven judges and seven deputies, and each is elected by two-thirds of those present.¹ The SPD, Linke and Grüne together hold 39. There is a wrinkle worth holding: because the threshold counts the room rather than the roll, an AfD walk-out would lower the bar. The party's power depends on turning up and voting no.

4.89%

THE CDU'S SHARE — 49,629 VOTES, DOWN 8.41 POINTS, BELOW THE THRESHOLD, **ZERO SEATS** FROM TWELVE²

Which brings up the date that matters more than Sunday. On **2 July** the outgoing Landtag voted on an amendment written to prevent precisely this blockade: after a deadlock the court itself would nominate three candidates for a simple-majority vote, as Saxony-Anhalt already allows. It failed 45 to 26. The CDU voted it down.³

He won the argument in July. In September he lost his seat.

Sebastian Ehlers, the CDU's legal-affairs spokesman in the chamber, explained the party's reasoning at the time: "An important minority right is lost. And it's permanent."³ He was right about permanence and wrong about whose right it was. Article 26 defines the opposition as the factions not supporting the

government; with a red-red-green coalition forming, that is the AfD alone, for five years.¹

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE ANALYSTS NOTICED FIRST

A time-filtered query over Hacker News for 20–23 September returned no German-election thread at all, and Reddit refused; nothing here is attributed to a forum. **Sebastian U. Bukow**, for the Heinrich-Böll-Stiftung on 23 September, calls a Landtag with no democratic opposition party "a first in German parliamentary politics", and puts the SPD's survival down to one thing: "the candidate makes all the difference."⁴ **Jan Müller** of Rostock, to dpa: red-red-green "requires a great deal of discipline".⁵

Turnout was **78.11 per cent**, up 7.34 points — this was not apathy. The AfD won 22 of 36 direct constituencies to the SPD's 14; the SPD held on 35.50 per cent and 29 seats.² The same Sunday, Berlin went the other way entirely — Die Linke to 25.7 per cent and 47 seats, up 13.4 points.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · THREE REASONS TO DISTRUST THE WORD DISASTER

The Nordkurier's **Frank Pubantz** calls it a Pyrrhic victory and notes the geography is a split, not a sweep: the AfD wins where it turns rural, the SPD takes almost every town above 40,000.⁷ **Holger Schmieding** of Berenberg judges it "more likely than not" that Merz weathers this, blaming energy prices rather than ideology.⁸ And the pollsters had it wrong: AFP's final Sunday numbers read SPD 37, AfD 36, CDU 6 — wrong party first, and the CDU above a threshold it missed.⁸

The trapdoor is Article 42. If nobody wins a majority of members within four weeks of the chamber convening, the Landtag must vote on dissolving itself — and if it declines, a fresh ballot is held the same day, won by whoever has the most votes.¹ A plurality. The largest single faction is the AfD. The chamber must convene by 20 October.

SOURCES 1 Verfassung des Landes Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, the Landtag's own April 2025 edition, Articles 26, 28, 42, 52 and 56, read in the German text. 2 Vorläufiges amtliches Endergebnis, Landtag Mecklenburg-Vorpommern and wahlrecht.de. 3 Nordkurier and SN-Aktuell on the 2 July vote; Ehlers quoted as reported. 4 Heinrich-Böll-Stiftung Brussels, 23 September 2026. 5 Jan Müller, University of Rostock, dpa interview, 21 September. 6 Statistik Berlin-Brandenburg, preliminary official result. 7 Nordkurier, 21 September, 05:30. 8 France 24 with AFP and The Local Germany, 20 September. Reuters, Bloomberg, CNN and CNBC refused every path; nothing here comes from them.

TURTLE BAY · THE MINAB FILE

A school in Hormozgan reaches the General Assembly podium

Four days after a UN mission put the phrase “war crime” beside a US Tomahawk, Trump asked from the podium whether to “annihilate” Iran — and dated any deal to after the November midterms.

Report A/HRC/63/61 was released on 17 September and formally presented to the 47-member Human Rights Council on **21 September**. Its chair is Sara Hossain; it rests on **73 witness interviews**, satellite imagery and video. Neither the United States nor Israel granted the mission access.¹

The finding: reasonable grounds to believe the United States committed the war crime of launching indiscriminate attacks in two strikes of **28 February**, killing at least **178 civilians**. At about 10:30 that morning the Shajareh Tayyebah primary school in Minab was struck twice — **156 dead, 120 of them schoolchildren and 26 of them women teaching**. At 17:10 a sports complex in Lamerd took 22 more, four of them children.²

221

CHILDREN KILLED BY IRANIAN STATE SECURITY FORCES ACROSS ALL 31 PROVINCES, IN THE SAME REPORT’S FINDING OF CRIMES AGAINST HUMANITY — SOME AS YOUNG AS TWO¹

The legal test is recklessness, not intent. The human-rights lawyer **Reed Brody** sets out what it rests on: outdated targeting data, a building readily identifiable as a school, and an administration that had weakened its collateral-damage systems. No consequence follows automatically — Washington has withdrawn from ICJ jurisdiction and Tehran is not an ICC party.²

WASHINGTON — THE WHITE HOUSE

“The only party in this conflict that has committed war crimes is the Iranian regime.” — Anna Kelly, deputy press secretary, 18 September; the Council’s output, she added, has been “unserious nonsense for decades”.³

GENEVA — THE UNITED KINGDOM

Kumar Iyer, the UK’s permanent representative, called Iran’s crackdown “the deadliest in the Islamic Republic’s history” — then handled the strikes in one passive sentence about “civilian deaths arising from the March 2026 conflict”. No mention of the United States, and the war dated to March, not February.⁴

The EU statement the same day does the same at greater length, and does not mention the United States at all.⁵ Two days later Trump spoke for 35 minutes: “Or do I annihilate the Islamic Republic and do it quickly?” — and then, “I believe we’ll make a deal, right after the election.”⁶

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

The mission was refused access by both states it investigated, so the targeting conclusion is inference from imagery, witnesses and open sources rather than from the strike packages. Release of the 28 February targeting file, showing Minab assessed as a military object on current intelligence, would overturn it. Nothing else will.

Pezeshkian answered on 23 September holding up photographs of a classroom: “Yes they did hit us, but we did not bend the knee.” The lone American diplomat in the US section walked out as he spoke.⁷

IN BRIEF · AROUND THE DESKS

Congo. The Bundibugyo epidemic reached **7,773 confirmed cases and 3,759 deaths** on 21 September — a 48.4 per cent fatality ratio, 839 patients in isolation. There is no licensed vaccine for this species.⁸

The scorecard nobody printed. The CDC’s own indicators for that response: 10.6 contacts traced per case against a target of twenty or more, and **59 per cent of deaths outside a treatment unit** against a target of zero.⁹

SOURCES 1 OHCHR press release on report A/HRC/63/61, 17 September 2026, read via GlobalSecurity.org’s verbatim mirror; ohchr.org returned 403 on every path. 2 Al Jazeera, 18 September, for the strike detail and Brody’s reading. 3 RFE/RL, 18 September, via the same mirror. 4 UK FCDO statement to HRC63, 21 September. 5 EEAS, HRC63 EU statement, 21 September. 6 CBS News, 22 September. 7 PBS NewsHour, 23 September. 8 ECDC epidemiological update, published 23 September, data to 21 September. 9 CDC, MMWR 75(35), indicators as at 21 August. 10 Médecins Sans Frontières. 11 Morocco World News, citing the Ministry of Interior. Casualty totals for the Iran war are OCHA’s where given; belligerents’ own claims are not printed.

THE TWO-AND-A-HALF-MONTH RULE

Your October power bill is priced off April's oil

Core inflation hit 2.2 per cent in August on a 17 per cent electricity tariff set by a window that closed in June. The window that sets next week's tariff was 15.5 per cent cheaper — and the September spike lands in January.

The mechanism is in a footnote. MAS and MTI, publishing August inflation on Tuesday, wrote it down: “The regulated electricity tariff for each quarter is set based largely on the average natural gas prices in the first two and a half months of the preceding quarter.”¹ Households are therefore always paying for an energy price that is roughly one quarter stale.

In 2026 that cut both ways and nobody noticed the first half. The April–June window — 1 January to 15 March — averaged **\$73.01** on the official dated-Brent series, and the tariff rose 2.1 per cent. The July–September window averaged **\$108.59**, and the tariff rose **17.0 per cent**, from 27.27 to **31.91 cents a kilowatt-hour** — about S\$17 a month on a four-room flat.²

-15.5%

THE 1 JULY–15 SEPTEMBER GAS WINDOW AGAINST THE ONE BEFORE IT, ON THE EIA'S OWN DAILY SERIES — \$91.77 AGAINST \$108.59. SP GROUP ANNOUNCES THE OCTOBER TARIFF ON OR ABOUT 29 SEPTEMBER³

Core inflation came in at **2.2 per cent**, the fastest since September 2024; all-items 2.3. Electricity and gas ran at 8.7. Services accelerated to 2.0 on airfares. The one component that *eased* was private transport, 7.5 from 8.0, on slower car-price rises.¹

A seventeen per cent increase arrived and the dominant public reaction was: is my meter broken?

THE CHATTER · THE TARIFF, READ FROM THE METER

A HardwareZone EDMW thread opened at the weekend — “How much is your electricity bill this month?” — ran to 110 replies, and the spread in it matters more than the level. The poster opened with a five-person household at “300+”, asking whether “something is wrong”; **Alphas** reported S\$150–160 for four with air-conditioning, **hachi** “\$150–170”, **cpuer** “mine 60+”. The advice given is to check the digital meter in the SP app. That is suspicion of the instrument, not outrage — which is what an opaque lagged pass-through produces.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · THREE WAYS THIS PAGE IS WRONG NEXT TUESDAY

Gas is not Brent. Singapore's contracts are oil-indexed with their own lags, which can run three to six months — long enough that April is still feeding through in October. Nothing published specifies the formula. Second, network, market-support and capacity components can offset a fuel fall. Third, the Q3 rise may have been under-recovered: April went up only 2.1 per cent when its window had already risen, and SP Group said the full effect was not yet “incorporated”.²

ALSO THIS WEEK

The state now scores families before anyone reports anything. MSF launched SAFER on 22 September, pooling police reports, CNB drug and sexual-offence arrests, household data and *preschool attendance* to flag children under seven. First two months: **70 cases** surfaced, one referred for early support, **one escalated to statutory intervention**, 68 to safety-plan review. A one-in-seventy statutory rate is the number to watch; a high false-positive rate is this class of system's standard failure mode.⁵

COE came off its record. Category A closed at **S\$131,890** on 23 September, down S\$1,119 from the S\$133,009 set two weeks earlier; Category B fell S\$2,001 to S\$133,000. All five categories closed lower on a quota of 3,229 against 4,210 bids.⁶

SOURCES 1 MAS and MTI, *Consumer Price Developments in August 2026*, 23 September, read as the published PDF including footnote 1. 2 SP Group's own tariff-revision releases for April–June and July–September 2026; the cents-per-kWh levels are read at Mothership, since SP publishes its table as images. 3 Window averages are this desk's own computation over the US EIA's Europe Brent Spot Price FOB daily file (RBRTed.xls) — dated Brent is a proxy for an oil-indexed gas window, not the input EMA uses, and the derivation is ours. 4 HardwareZone EDMW, quoted as posted. 5 Mothership and AsiaOne, 22 September; the 70/1/1/68 breakdown is Mothership's alone. 6 MOM, *Labour Market Report — Second Quarter 2026*, 21 September; Little Big Red Dot for the 23 September COE bidding, since onemotoring.lta.gov.sg returned 404. 7 Mothership, with Wong quoted as reported. 8 MTI's own newsroom releases of 19–22 September. Straits Times, CNA, Reuters, SingStat and mas.gov.sg all refused this build; the July MPS is read via Mondo Visione's verbatim republication. 7 Little Big Red Dot on the 23 September bidding; onemotoring.lta.gov.sg returned 404. 8 Mothership, with Wong quoted as reported. 9 MTI's own newsroom releases of 19–22 September.

BUY IT ONCE · MERINO BASE LAYERS AND TRAVEL TEES

The cheaper shirt has the finer wool. Price is not the spec.

A \$65 tee runs 17.5 microns with a nylon core and taped shoulder seams; the \$90 one runs 18.9 and the \$150 made-to-order one runs 19.5. What the money buys is finish, fit and a story.

Start with the itch, because it is mechanical, not allergic. Fibres above **30 microns** are stiff enough to poke rather than bend against skin, and the trade rule is that once more than **5 per cent** of a fabric's fibres exceed 30µm it reads as scratchy.¹ The published research — Naylor, Stanton and Speijers, 2014 — is paywalled, so the per-micron satisfaction curves are not printed here.²

Fibre ends cause prickle and also cause pilling, which is why **staple length** matters as much as micron. Then weight: **140–150 gsm** is the ceiling at 31°C, **190** an aircon shirt, **200–260** a ski base layer and a separate purchase.³

17.5µ vs 18.9µ

RIDGE MERINO JOURNEY, **US\$65**, 145GSM, AGAINST ICEBREAKER'S 150 TECH LITE III, **US\$90**, 146GSM. SAME WEIGHT. THE CHEAP ONE IS FINER, AND CORE-SPUN⁴

Which brings up construction, the thing the category argues about. Merino is intrinsically weak and weaker wet; the traditional fix is twist, the modern fix a continuous filament. **Wool&Prince** spins a 17.5µ core with two nylon filaments, 78/22; **Ridge's** is 87/13. That is engineering, not cheapening — it substitutes for twist, so you keep loft. The purist's price is real: the garment is no longer compostable and sheds microfibre. Nobody sells you both.⁴

Two white-label truths: **Nuyarn** belongs to **TMC Ltd of New Zealand**, not Südrolle, whose own core-spun process is **Betaspun**. And **Wool&Prince** runs **two factories for two tees** on one shelf.⁵

THE CHATTER · WHAT HOLDS UP AFTER THREE YEARS

Reddit, Styleforum and Trailspace all refused; these are Hacker News owners via the Algolia API. The strongest long-term report is for the cheapest shirt — **mlleonhard** on a multi-year Minus33 stack: "Extremely durable fabric and stitching... I cannot tell which one is the oldest." The regret names one brand: **lhl**, "I've paid \$80+ for a shirt... and have experienced wear/holes sometimes in months."⁶

109 → 400

WEARS PER GARMENT LIFE, CURRENT PRACTICE AGAINST BEST PRACTICE. CLOSING THAT GAP CUT LIFE-CYCLE IMPACTS **60–68 PER CENT** — MORE THAN WASHING, DRYING AND MACHINE EFFICIENCY COMBINED. BEST PRACTICE IS 14 WEARS PER WASH⁷

Singapore: **X-Boundaries** at Mandarin Gallery prices the 150 Tech Lite at **S\$129.90** in store. The US\$90 shirt lands near S\$116 before freight and 9 per cent GST — rough parity, which is unusual in a market where importing normally wins.⁸

THE SCEPTIC · A MACHINE-WASHABLE MERINO TEE IS A PLASTIC-COATED WOOL TEE

Superwash erodes the cuticle scales with chlorine, then seals the fibre in **Hercosett**, a polyamide-epichlorohydrin resin — "a petroleum-based plastic". It costs warmth retention and elasticity, and rules out GOTS certification.⁹ Nuyarn's own figures also disagree with themselves — 53 per cent more air resistance on its site, 35 in *Textile World* — against a control never named.¹⁰ And Icebreaker's warranty is one year: "Damage that occurs after a year is usually caused by wear and tear." Minus33 gives two on a \$69.99 shirt, five on the socks it makes itself.¹¹

NEXT ON THE BENCH — PICK THE NEXT CATEGORY

Coffee grinders — burr geometry is most of the cup.

Tea ware (teapots, kettles & gaiwan) — zisha, tetsubin, and what the clay does to the brew.

Kitchen scales & thermometers — the 0.1g bench, and which readings are theatre.

SOURCES 1 WeatherWool's technical page, written by wool classer Bob Padula, for the 30-micron rigidity mechanism and the 5 per cent rule. 2 Naylor, Stanton & Speijers, "Skin comfort of base layer wool garments, Part 2", *Textile Research Journal* 84(14), DOI 10.1177/0040517514523174 — record confirmed via Crossref; Sage returned 403 and the full text was not read. 3 Weights read at each maker's own product page; Icebreaker publishes a 75–460+ warmth scale. 4 ridgemerino.com, woolandprince.com, icebreaker.com, minus33.com, all read September 2026. 5 nuyarn.com and Liongtex for TMC's ownership; suedwollgroup.com for Betaspun; ortovox.com credits it. 6 Hacker News via its Algolia API, quoted as posted. 7 Wiedemann et al., *Int. J. LCA*, DOI 10.1007/s11367-021-01909-x, open access, PDF text extracted. 8 xboundaries.com; Singapore Customs on the S\$400 CIF relief. 9 Farm & Fiber Knits on the chlorine-Hercosett process, quoted verbatim. 10 nuyarn.com against *Textile World*, January 2023; BackpackingLight thread 91415. 11 icebreaker.com and minus33.com warranty pages.

THE ENTITY-LISTED PLAINTIFF

Munich hands YMTC an injunction against Micron, on rights nobody examined

Two German utility models, registered in 2020 without a prior-art search and published only last October, now bar an American memory maker from selling NAND in Germany — while the US patent office has already voided the same family.

This is the export-control story with the polarity reversed. On **18 September** the 7th Civil Chamber of the Landgericht München I, presiding judge Dr Oliver Schoen, granted **Yangtze Memory Technologies** — a Chinese state-backed firm on the US Entity List — injunctions against **Micron** in cases 7 O 12615/25 and 7 O 12614/25. Three further cases were adjourned.¹

What the rights are is the load-bearing fact. Both are *Gebrauchsmuster* — German utility models, **registered without substantive examination**, valid ten years. DE202020006166U1, on the staircase structure of a three-dimensional storage device, was filed in March 2020 and published on **13 October 2025**. A right nobody searched, granted on filing, enforceable five and a half years later.²

7 of 26

MICRON'S WINS AT THE US PATENT TRIAL AND APPEAL BOARD AGAINST YMTC — 26 PETITIONS, 19 PATENTS, 251 CLAIMS. THE SEVENTH, IN SEPTEMBER, VOIDED THE **SAME STAIRCASE FAMILY** FOR OBVIOUSNESS³

Which is the sceptic's case, and it is on a docket rather than in a quote. In early September the PTAB held all challenged claims of YMTC's US 12,010,838 — "Staircase Structure for Memory Device" — unpatentable over five prior references. It is not a clean sweep: Micron lost outright on US 10,879,164 in June and kept only five of sixteen claims in July. But a first-instance infringement finding on an unexamined right settles nothing about validity, and the cancellation route at the Bundespatentgericht is live.³

Micron has appealed and says it is challenging the rights' validity.⁴ The parallel US case, 19 patents across two complaints, has been stayed pending those reviews; YMTC moved to lift the stay this month.⁵ Timing sharpens it: Micron reports fiscal Q4

on **30 September**, having guided to **\$50.0bn** of revenue at a gross margin near 86 per cent.⁶

THE CHATTER · READ THE SILENCE

There isn't any, and that is the finding. A Hacker News search for "Micron YMTC" returns two items from 2023 — three points and one point, one comment each. Nothing in 2026. Coverage was immediate but derivative, all of it tracing to one specialist outlet in Munich. A Chinese firm winning an enforceable injunction against an American memory maker in a European court drew less discussion than a fridge firmware bug the same week.⁷

The context is a market in which memory has stopped behaving like a commodity. DRAM module revenue reached **\$21.2bn in 2025, up 59 per cent** against 7 the year before, and TrendForce names the mechanism: cloud providers raised server-DRAM orders for agentic AI, which "limited DRAM suppliers' allocations for PC and consumer applications".⁸

And the crowding-out has reached the living room: TrendForce cut October panel-fab utilisation to **79.6 per cent** and put fourth-quarter TV panel costs up **4 to 7 per cent** on the same cause.⁹

THE SCEPTIC · THE QUIET CONSOLIDATION NOBODY COVERED

Export controls point at lithography and logic. Silicon-photonics assembly tooling — the machines that align fibre to die at sub-micron tolerance — sits outside that perimeter, and a Suzhou firm has quietly consolidated it. **RoboTechnik**, which owns Bremen's **ficonTEC**, launched a Hong Kong listing on 21 September, about US\$800m, its prospectus claiming **20.5 per cent** of the global market. Read it sceptically: the research was commissioned by the issuer; H1 net profit was **RMB 6.3m** on RMB 608.1m — a one per cent margin; one customer is a third of revenue; and its photovoltaic unit sales fell from 1,932 to 110 in two years.¹⁰

IN BRIEF

SOURCES 1 ip fray, the specialist outlet of record for German patent litigation, for the ruling, the chamber, the judge and the docket numbers — single-sourced, as no second outlet published the case numbers. 2 Google Patents, DE202020006166U1, for applicant, filing and publication dates and status — an independent corroboration of the right's existence and ownership. 3 cloudnews.tech on PGR2025-00021 and the PTAB tally; a low-profile outlet, treated as indicative. 4 Micron's statement as reported by TechNode; no Micron release carrying it verbatim could be reached. 5 ip fray on the N.D. Cal. stay. 6 Micron's own Q3 FY26 release via GlobeNewswire and its investor-relations announcement of the 30 September date. 7 Hacker News via its Algolia API. 8 TrendForce, 22 September. 9 TrendForce, 21 September; the enterprise-SSD release is directional only and carries no percentages. 10 TechNode reading the prospectus, and The Standard (Hong Kong) on the offer; the two give slightly different H1 figures and the prospectus set is used. 11 TrendForce, 18 September. 12 Interconnects, 21 September. 13 Semiconductor Industry Association. Reuters, Bloomberg, SCMP, Digitimes and Reddit all refused; nothing here is theirs.

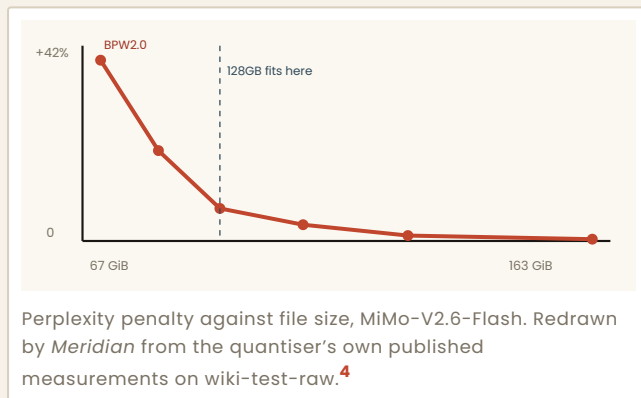
309 BILLION PARAMETERS, MIT LICENCE, AND A TAPE MEASURE

Xiaomi opened MiMo-V2.6. Here is what actually fits.

The card says 67.9 per cent on DeepSWE. The quant that fits a 96-gigabyte card is 41.7 per cent worse at predicting text — and the quant that fits 128GB cleanly did not exist until Tuesday.

The release first, then the tape measure. Xiaomi published three open-weights models on 21–22 September under **MIT: Pro** at 1.02T total and 42B active, **Flash at 309B/15B**, and a refreshed 9B distill. Flash is a sparse mixture of experts, 48 layers, 256 routed experts with eight active, a 128-token sliding window and a one-million-token context, omnimodal in — text, image, video, audio — text out.¹ Artificial Analysis ranks Pro first of 114 models on its intelligence index.²

Toolchain support took **eight hours and fifty-one minutes**. llama.cpp PR #29257 opened at 03:47 UTC on 22 September and merged at 12:38, approved by CISC and ggerganov; both variants use mxfp4 expert quantisation, and vision needed no runtime change. The author disclosed that AI wrote the mxfp4 packing.³



Now the measurements, published by the quantiser and re-derived here from the byte counts in the Hugging Face file tree, which match to two decimals. **MXFP4 at 162.89 GiB** is effectively lossless: +0.07 per cent perplexity, KL divergence indistinguishable from zero. Q3_K is 137.75 GiB at +0.62 per cent. **BPW2.5 at 90.14 GiB** costs +11.54 per cent. And **BPW2.0 at 66.99 GiB** — the only one that fits a 96GB card with room for the projector and a cache — costs **+41.69 per cent**, at a KL divergence of 0.4776.⁴

So: 24GB and 48GB machines get the 9B, not Flash, at any published quant. A 128GB box wants BPW2.5, leaving 25 to 35 gigabytes for the 1.56GB vision projector, the cache and the operating system. Above 160GB, take MXFP4. One detail the repo gives away: there is a measurement file for **BPW3.0** — which would land near 110 GiB, the natural 128GB choice — and no BPW3.0 weights.⁴

THE CHATTER · THE THREAD WAS ABOUT MEMORY, NOT INTELLIGENCE

1,118 points and 477 comments. **alfiedotwtf**, on 128GB: “Yeah :(Close but yet so far. Nobody has released a Q3 that fits so far” — written before BPW2.5 landed the next day. **adrian_b** put SSD-backed inference at roughly one token a second on consumer kit, fifteen on enterprise. **embedding-shape** observed Flash reasoning *longer* than Pro, the opposite of expectation.⁵

THE SCEPTIC · THE PITCH WAS TOOL USE, AND TOOL USE WAS BROKEN

ggerganov flagged it in the merge review; it was filed as issue #29319 on 23 September. The detection logic in `common/chat.cpp` substring-matches on `<function=`, routing MiMo's template to the Qwen3-Coder XML parser, whose grammar it does not satisfy: the call never closes, generation runs to `max_tokens`, and it returns `finish_reason: length`. Now fixed — but every headline benchmark on the card is agentic.⁶ Three of Flash's benchmarks are Xiaomi's own, with no published construction, and Flash *beats* Pro on CyberGym while Pro crushes it on exploit generation, 47.9 to 6.0.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

vLLM 0.30.0, published 22 September, 762 commits from 315 contributors. “Fast Start” holds post-quantised, tensor-parallel-sharded weights in GPU memory so a restart maps them over CUDA IPC instead of re-reading from disk. No throughput figures are published, so none are printed. MiMo-V2.6 is *not* in its supported-model list.⁷

SOURCES 1 The XiaomiMiMo model cards for MiMo-V2.6-Flash-RL and Pro-RL on Hugging Face — architecture, licence and every benchmark figure. mimo.xiaomi.com is fully JavaScript-rendered and returns only a title, so the cards are the canonical machine-readable source. 2 artificialanalysis.ai. 3 GitHub, llama.cpp PR #29257, with timestamps, reviewers and the author's own disclosure. 4 The AesSedai/MiMo-V2.6-Flash-GGUF README for the quant table, perplexity and KL divergence, with sizes independently recomputed from the repository's file-tree API. 5 Hacker News item 49792730, quoted as posted. 6 GitHub, llama.cpp issue #29319. 7 The vLLM v0.30.0 release notes and the project's Atom feed, which carries the unambiguous timestamp; the rendered releases page misdates it.

THE DESK-SIDE DATACENTRE

The M5 Ultra went on sale, and the memory it was built for now costs more than the machine used to

US\$5,499 on Tuesday, S\$7,999 here. It beats an RTX 5090 at long context by outlasting it — and the 512GB tier the whole pitch rests on does not exist until late October.

Both boxes reached shelves on 22 September. Mac Studio M5 Max is US\$2,499, M5 Ultra US\$5,499; Singapore lists them from S\$3,499 and S\$7,999, with the 36-core, 80-core Ultra from S\$9,949. The Ultra is Apple's first **quad-die** part — two dual-die M5 Max SoCs joined over UltraFusion above 4.4TB/s — with 1.2TB/s of memory bandwidth, half again on the previous generation, and up to 512GB unified.¹

The number the reader wants is the head-to-head, and MacStories published it. Generating on a 27-billion dense model at 8K, 64K and 128K of prompt: an **RTX 5090 rig does 59, 51 and 44** tokens a second; the **M5 Ultra does 48, 39 and 32** — and then 24 at 256K, where the 5090 has no entry, because it has run out of video memory. Time to first token at 256K falls from 246 seconds on an M3 Ultra to **102**.²

US\$12,299

TOM'S HARDWARE'S AS-TESTED CONFIGURATION — 36 CORES, 80 GPU CORES, 256GB, 4TB — BACKORDERED **16 TO 18 WEEKS**. MEMORY AND STORAGE ARE SOLDERED³

So the machine wins by not falling over, which is a real kind of winning and an expensive one. The base Ultra is **US\$1,500 above** the M3 Ultra's US\$3,999 start; the Mac mini has gone from US\$599 in November 2024 to US\$799 in June to **US\$899** now, on 16GB and 256GB. Engadget puts Apple's LPDDR5X cost at roughly US\$6 a gigabyte earlier in the year against US\$10–11 now, which covers about US\$2,500 of a US\$3,800 price step. The rest is margin and hedging.⁴

THE CHATTER · 269 POINTS, AND THE ARITHMETIC EVERYONE DOES

MacRumors' forums and Reddit both refused; this is Hacker News, read in full. **simonw** posted the token table above, the chart Apple would rather you skipped. **_hugerobots_** made the buy-once case: "A stack of Macs is up and running without digging trenches, an electrician on staff and a department of PhDs to justify the spend." **andrekanre** ran the other sum: "5 years of (200/month) tokens at that price, meanwhile an rtx 5090 pc is about half that..." **redox99** landed the technical objection: "A dense 27B doesn't really make sense for the Mac. A MoE makes way more sense when you have modest bandwidth but lots of memory."⁵

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE BENCHMARK CONTRADICTS THE BANNER

Apple's headline is "up to 4.3× faster AI performance." Tom's Hardware's own suite has the M5 Ultra **losing Blender CPU rendering** to two Threadrippers and a 56-core Xeon, and managing **66 FPS** at 1080p in Cyberpunk with ray tracing — in line with an RTX 5070.³ **bigyabai**, repeatedly, on the efficiency claim: "It's likely that a stack of Macs will draw more power for slower prefill/decode than equivalently priced Nvidia GPUs." **mathisfun123** supplied the logo-tax line: the same reason people "spend huge amounts of money on rolexes when seikos work better."⁵ And if the 512GB SKU lands above US\$10,000 in late October, the 256GB ceiling is the product.

STILL ON THE SHELF

STILL ON THE SHELF

The configuration the whole pitch rests on does not ship yet. Apple states that a Mac Studio with 512GB of unified memory "arrives in late October". Every review so far tested 256GB. Until it lands, the frontier-models-on-your-desk claim has a 256GB ceiling, and the honest purchases are the tiers beneath it.¹

Beats 360 cushion kits — the No. 111 prediction resolves early, and wrong. We said after 31 October. They are buyable now: list **US\$49.99**, the black Performance Knit SKU on sale at **US\$9.99**, in stock — and "compatible exclusively with Beats 360", so not a Studio Pro accessory.⁶

SOURCES 1 Apple Newsroom's availability release of 22 September and its August introduction; Singapore prices read at Apple's own SG store. 2 MacStories, Federico Viticci, 21 September, on a 256GB unit; the comparison table as published. 3 Tom's Hardware, Andrew E. Freedman, 21 September. 4 Apple's 2025 release for the M3 Ultra baseline; Tom's Hardware for the mini's price ladder; Engadget, Steve Dent, 21 September, for the memory-cost estimate — single-sourced, and the Apple line Engadget carries could not be found on any Apple page. 5 Hacker News item 49787313, quoted as posted. 6 beatsbydre.com, read 23 September. 7 soundcore.com's own product page; ecoustics for the IFA announcement, which conflicts with the maker on the Liberty Buds 2's ingress rating — the maker's figures are used. 8 specs.com. Reuters and Bloomberg were not used. 6 beatsbydre.com, read 23 September.

FOUR GREATEST HITS, ONE PAIR OF BARRELS

Grönefeld shows the Quadrivium, and a seven-and-a-half-second remontoire is the whole argument

€280,000 for 28 pieces in tantalum, shown under photo embargo in April and photographed only yesterday — by which time the brothers had already stopped taking orders.

State the peg honestly. The watch was shown to a small group at Watches and Wonders in April with **no photography permitted**, because it had been finished the day before the fair; Grönefeld's own note in May set the prices and ended, "Please do not ask for pictures. Pictures will be available at the end of the year." The press release and the first official photographs landed on **23 September**, ahead of the maker's own schedule, carrying detail never previously published. This is not an announcement; it is the moment the watch became visible.¹

A mainspring does not deliver constant torque. It delivers a decaying ramp, and an escapement fed a decaying ramp keeps decaying time. A *remontoire d'égalité* interposes a second, tiny spring between barrel and escapement; the mainspring rewinds that small spring at a fixed interval, so the escapement only ever sees a near-constant output. Grönefeld rewinds theirs **every 7.5 seconds**, which is unusually long — most do it every second.²

473 / 49

COMPONENTS AND JEWELS IN THE HAND-WOUND CALIBRE.
NEW ON TUESDAY: **CONCENTRIC TWIN BARRELS IN SERIES**
— THERE TO FLATTEN THE TORQUE CURVE, NOT TO EXTEND
A MODEST 50-HOUR RESERVE²

The trade is visual and mechanical at once. A longer interval means a slower, larger, watchable governor — the spinning disc at nine o'clock is a fly-governor damping the shock of each release into the train — and fewer rewind events robbing the barrel. A one-minute flying tourbillon at six then averages positional error, and because its cage carries a stop lever that catches at the sixty-second mark, the watch has a true zero-reset: you set it against a time signal, not a sweep. **Four complications, one argument** — keep the escapement's diet identical from hour one to hour fifty.²

A watch whose entire premise is chronometric stability publishes nothing chronometric.

40.0mm by 11.30mm, tantalum now and platinum at €310,000 later, 28 pieces each. Delivery has already slipped from "late 2026 and early 2027" in May to **2027** on Tuesday. And the collection page publishes no price at all, only this: "Due to high interest and limited capacity, we will unfortunately not be able to accept orders for the time being." For 56 watches across two metals, demand was settled before the photographs existed.³

THE CHATTER · THIN, AND WE SAY SO

The images were under twenty-four hours old at press time. Monochrome's comment thread on the Introducing piece was **empty**. Henki Time ran the release as "The Bulldog Edition" and reproduced the brand's copy with no verdict added, which is itself the story of how a 56-piece run gets covered. WatchUSeek and Reddit refused this build, so no forum sentiment is asserted. The loudest signal is commercial: the order book is shut.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · NO RATE, NO AMPLITUDE, NO WATER RESISTANCE

Grönefeld publishes no chronometry data whatsoever — no COSC, no in-house certification, no deviation figures — on either the news page or the collection page. Monochrome's spec table also records **no mention of water resistance**. And the diminishing-returns line is stark: the tantalum Grönograaf was **€165,000** in 2022, in the same case and the same design language, with its own centrifugal-governor reset. Roughly **€115,000** buys the tourbillon-and-remontoire pairing over a chronograph — a 70 per cent step in four years. Whether that is worth it is an aesthetic judgment, and it should be printed as one.⁵

ALSO ON THE BENCH

SOURCES 1 gronefeld.com's own news post of 5 May 2026, quoted verbatim, against Monochrome Watches' Introducing piece of 23 September, 14:01 UTC. 2 Monochrome, 23 September, for the calibre detail first published that day — 49 jewels, the twin barrels in series, the three-spoke steel cage and the sixty-second tourbillon stop — and for the note that a remontoire "very often" rewinds every second. 3 gronefeld.com/collection/1941-quadrivium, quoted verbatim, which publishes no price. 4 Monochrome's comment thread, read empty; Henki Time, 23 September. 5 Monochrome's 2022 Grönograaf introduction for the €155,000 steel and €165,000 tantalum baseline. 6 Monochrome First Look, 23 September, 08:01 UTC, with both references. 7 Monochrome, 23 September, and Fratello's hands-on by Balazs Ferenczi the same day, which carries the partnership disclosure.

THE ENCORE NOBODY WAS PROMISED

Swift reopens the biggest-selling album week in history

She told fans the twelve-track configuration was final. Tracks thirteen to sixteen arrive on Friday, eleven months after a debut week of 4.002 million US units — and two days before she collects an award.

The *Life of a Showgirl: The Encore* was announced on **23 September** for release on **25 September**: four new songs numbered thirteen to sixteen on an expanded album — “Patient Zero,” “Cleveland!,” “Pink Clouding,” “Babylon.” The first of those had been announced separately the day before, giving it less than twenty-four hours alone.¹

The record being extended is the one worth restating. The album took over **4 million US** and over **5.5 million global** album-equivalent units in week one — the biggest first week in music history — with **1.5 billion streams**, 250 million on Spotify for the standard edition on debut, and the largest vinyl week in Nielsen history at over a million units, the first album ever past that mark.²

1–12

THE FIRST ALBUM EVER TO PLACE SONGS AT EVERY POSITION FROM ONE TO TWELVE, UNINTERRUPTED, ON THE HOT 100 — AND AN 87TH WEEK AT NO. 1 ON THE BILLBOARD 200²

The four songs were written with **Max Martin and Shellback** in Sweden after the album’s release — the pair Swift had not worked with between 2017 and *Showgirl*. Her own account: “there was a studio there and we did what we do when we feel anything at all: We wrote more songs.”³

THE CHATTER · A SUBORDINATE CLAUSE DOES THE WORK

Pitchfork’s Alex Suskind introduced the Encore with the sharpest thing yet written about it: not to be confused with *The Life of a Showgirl + Acoustic Collection*, *So Glamorous Cabaret Version*, and *So Punk on the Internet Version*. Four configurations of one 2025 album before this one. Variety’s Chris Willman logged the reversal plainly: fans had assumed there would be no deluxe edition “because, at the time, Swift had assured fans that she felt pleased with the exact 12-song configuration.” Reddit refused this build, so no fan-forum sentiment is asserted.¹

THE SCEPTIC · THE STATED REASON AND THE COMMERCIAL REASON ARE NOT THE SAME REASON

A Friday street date lands two days before Swift collects the inaugural Artist Director Honors at the VMAs, on the fifth configuration of a 2025 album. Gratitude is the motive given; a release plan is the other thing visible. One mechanism we will not assert: an expanded edition under the same title conventionally accrues to that title’s chart total rather than debuting separately — but billboard.com redirected to a host answering **HTTP 402 Payment Required**, so Billboard’s and Luminate’s own rules were not read. It runs here as an open question until the chart dated 10 October settles it. What would clear the cynical read: no bundled physical variants, and no re-entry into the top five.¹

IN BRIEF

A seven-year-old film for number one. Disney’s *Avengers: Endgame Encore* is tracked at **US\$25–28m** this weekend against *Resident Evil*’s second frame at US\$24–26m. The No. 111 delta, with actuals: the reboot opened to **US\$60,152,878** on 3,684 screens and reached **US\$72,360,910** by Tuesday, which took US\$6.9m alone, up 30 per cent on Monday. A drop near 58 per cent is normal-to-good for a hard-R horror opener this size; what it will not do is hold first place.⁴

SOURCES 1 Pitchfork, Alex Suskind, 23 September, for the announcement, the running order and the configuration list; Variety, Chris Willman, 23 September, for the reversal. 2 Universal Music’s official press release of 13 October 2025 — the source for every first-week figure here; the widely-quoted 4.002 million decimal is Billboard’s and is printed as reported, since the label release says only “over 4 million”. 3 Swift’s own social statement of 23 September, via Variety. 4 Box Office Mojo’s domestic weekend 38 chart and The Numbers’ daily chart for 22 September, both read directly; Variety, Rebecca Rubin, 23 September, for the projections and the budgets. 5 Pitchfork, Walden Green, and Variety, Jem Aswad, both 23 September. 6 officialcharts.com and Pitchfork; Variety for the YouTube and Sony items. No image runs with the Bad Brains or box-office items: the available frames are a named photographer’s and a stock agency’s, and neither was cleared.

AGE ASSURANCE

The year a twelve-year-old becomes a regulated category

Britain's under-16 ban moved from announcement to machinery last Friday — and the same fact sheet quietly commits to mandatory break prompts for under-18s using AI chatbots, the first national rulebook to treat a chatbot like a slot machine.

No. 110 covered school phone bans. This is a different lever entirely: statutory, platform-side, and enforced by Ofcom rather than a form teacher. The UK fact sheet, updated **18 September**, bars under-16s outright from Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, Snapchat, Facebook and X. Messaging services — WhatsApp, Signal — are excluded. The timetable, verbatim: “The first set of Regulations will be laid before the end of the year, and the changes should be implemented in **Spring 2027**.”¹

Sixteen- and seventeen-year-olds get a lighter regime that is worth reading now, because it is what she ages into: livestreaming, stranger contact, autoplay and personalised feeds off by default, plus an **overnight curfew from midnight to six**. And the line nobody has picked up — a commitment to **mandatory breaks for under-18s using AI chatbots**. No draft statutory instrument text exists yet, so that is the fact sheet's word alone.¹

£632.5m

GOING INTO ALTERNATIVE YOUTH ACTIVITIES AND ENRICHMENT ALONGSIDE THE RESTRICTIONS — THE “AND INSTEAD, WHAT?” HALF OF THE POLICY, USUALLY DROPPED FROM THE COVERAGE¹

The consultation ran March to May and reports nine in ten parents backing an under-16 ban and two-thirds of young people supporting restrictions on certain platforms — a self-selecting sample, not a probability one, and it should be read that way. Ofcom will specify the verification methods, and the government has commissioned research on circumvention by VPN.¹

We will not know whether this works until 2027, and the study that will tell us is already running.

That study is the honest centre of the story. A pre-registered independent evaluation of Australia's Social Media Minimum Age is following **4,121 young people aged 10 to 16**, combining surveys, passive tracking and qualitative work; the author list includes Amy Orben, Mitch Prinstein, Susan Sawyer and Jeff Hancock. It is a protocol. There are no results.²

THE CHATTER · PARENTS GOT THERE FIRST, AND ARE MOVING ON

The UK campaign **Smartphone Free Childhood** runs a “Parent Pact” — no smartphone before fourteen, no social media before sixteen — signed, it says, on behalf of over **190,000 children** across more than half of UK schools. That figure is self-reported and single-sourced to the campaign. Its public line is that the ban is a floor, not a ceiling, and it is already pivoting to helping families implement the law and to parents whose children *already* have devices.³

THE SCEPTIC · TWO DISSENTS, NEITHER OF THEM ALARMIST

The civil-liberties objection is about access, not risk. The EFF's **Paige Collings and Jillian C. York**: “There is still no widely available way to verify age online without compromising privacy — but even if there were, broad restrictions on social media will inevitably limit access to lawful speech.” Young people, they add, will lose “educational videos on YouTube, local events on Facebook” and contact with distant family. “Young people deserve better than a policy built on panic.”⁴ The evidential objection comes from the same researcher running the Australian evaluation: **Amy Orben** published a BMJ editorial in July titled “The UK's social media ban is a gamble in the face of uncertainty.” We could confirm the title, author, journal and DOI, but bmj.com returned 403 — so the text is not quoted here.⁵ The falsification test is dated: the Australian evaluation reporting in 2027 no improvement in wellbeing despite a measured fall in account-holding.

A NOTE ON WHAT THIS PAGE IS

SOURCES ¹ GOV.UK, *Fact sheet: new rules to protect children online*, updated 18 September 2026 — read at source; every figure and both quoted passages are from it. It is a government policy document, not a study. ² Stevic, Chen, Lee, Orben, Prinstein, Sawyer, Hancock et al., *Evaluation of the Social Media Minimum Age on Australian Young People: A Study Protocol*, PsyArXiv v4, 5 July 2026, DOI 10.31234/osf.io/u5zn6_v4 — a preprint protocol, read via the Europe PMC core record. ³ smartphonefreechildhood.org; the 190,000 figure is the campaign's own and is not independently verified. ⁴ Electronic Frontier Foundation, 19 June 2026, quoted verbatim. ⁵ Orben A, *BMJ*, 7 July 2026, DOI 10.1136/bmj-2026-100202 — title, author, journal, date and DOI confirmed from the Europe PMC core record; bmj.com returned 403 and the editorial itself was not read. esafety.gov.au returned 503 on four attempts, so the Australian account-holding figures circulating in search summaries are not printed.

DEVELOPMENT

Early puberty nudges the brain — by about a rounding error

A study of 10,722 children that also ran a genetic causal test found earlier puberty tracks with slightly worse memory at twelve. Its authors say plainly that the effect is too small to matter for any individual child.

The design is what makes it worth a page. Dinkelbach and colleagues, in the *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry* this month, combined the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development cohort — children enrolled at nine or ten and followed through early adolescence, which is precisely this band — with a **two-sample Mendelian randomization**, using genetic variants as instruments to test causality rather than association. The instrument studies are large: menarche **n = 632,955**, executive functioning **n = 427,037**.¹

The associations are real and they are tiny. Earlier puberty against worse picture-sequence memory: **$\beta = 0.04$** in girls, 95 per cent confidence interval 0.02 to 0.06, and the same in boys. Word-list learning: 0.05 in girls, 0.03 in boys. Working memory moved only in boys, at 0.03. The causal estimate — later menarche toward better executive function — came in at **0.005 per year, interval 0.000 to 0.011**. The lower bound touches zero.¹

$\beta = 0.04$

FOUR HUNDREDTHS OF A STANDARD DEVIATION. ON ANY CLASSROOM MEASURE THIS IS INVISIBLE FOR ONE CHILD. REPORTED AS “EARLY PUBERTY HARMS YOUR DAUGHTER’S BRAIN,” IT HAS BEEN MIS-SCALED BY TWO ORDERS OF MAGNITUDE

The authors say so themselves: effect sizes were small with limited individual clinical significance, and they argue only that population-level implications warrant further work.¹ The honest headline is that this is detectable at population scale and meaningless at the kitchen table. What would retire it: a replication in ALSPAC or Generation R returning

an interval that crosses zero, or a sibling-comparison design nulling the observational betas.

THE CHATTER · THE SAME GROUP IS PUBLISHING BOTH HALVES OF A CHAIN

There is an adjacent preprint from the same Essen and Düsseldorf team — Bläschke and colleagues, medRxiv, January 2026, n = 10,786 — reporting that the very-high-screen-time group, four to twelve and a half hours a day, reached mid-puberty about **two and a half months earlier**, with stronger effects in girls. It is a preprint, not peer reviewed, and observational. The thing worth noticing is the structure: one team is publishing a “screens to earlier puberty to cognition” chain while its own peer-reviewed half says the cognition link is trivial.²

THE SCEPTIC · THE HARM HAS A POSTCODE, AND THE SAMPLE IS OLDER THAN SHE IS

Stanford’s platform-by-platform survey, published in *JAMA Pediatrics* on 18 September, is the most useful adjacent finding of the week and it must be labelled: participants were **13 to 17, mean age 14.9, n = 472**. That band does not contain a twelve-year-old. Read it as what is coming. In four weeks, **44.7 per cent** witnessed harassment and 29.8 experienced it; online exceeded offline for violent imagery **10.7 to 1.6 per cent** and for unwanted sexual images 13.4 to 2.0; **51.5 per cent** reported technology interfering with sleep. The platform spread is the actual news: feeling worse about oneself was reported by **16.6 per cent of Instagram users against 4.1 per cent of YouTube users**, and 42.2 per cent of TikTok users blamed that platform for lost sleep. Print the conflict line too — several authors disclosed current or prior employment at Meta and YouTube, and the sample is modest for platform-level estimates.³

HOW TO READ ALL OF THIS AT TWELVE

SOURCES 1 Dinkelbach L, Serio B, Valk S, Weisner FE, Bläschke LM, Peters T, Hinney A, Schmidt B, Hirtz R, “Puberty timing and cognitive functioning: insights from the ABCD study and Mendelian randomization,” *J Child Psychol Psychiatry*, September 2026, DOI 10.1111/jcpp.70220. Read as the Europe PMC core record, which carries the verbatim abstract and every effect size and interval quoted; the publisher page is subscription-only and was not read. Funded by 23 NIH grants plus DFG FU 356/12-2. 2 Bläschke L et al., *Screen Time and Puberty Timing: Findings from the ABCD Study*, medRxiv, 26 January 2026, DOI 10.64898/2026.01.26.26344850 — preprint, not peer reviewed, read via Europe PMC. 3 Lee AY, Lim CHJ, Liu SX et al., *JAMA Pediatrics*, published online 18 September 2026 — abstract page read at jamanetwork.com; full text paywalled. Cross-sectional, nationally representative panel survey, four-week recall, n = 472 aged 13–17. Funded by the Stanford Center for Digital Health and the USC Marshall Neely Center; multiple authors disclosed technology-industry employment or consulting. No image on this page depicts an identifiable child.

THE CHAIN, LINK BY LINK

Thirteen of the fifteen basis points were real. That is the whole story.

The ten-year rose to 5.11 per cent on Wednesday and the breakeven moved two basis points. The bond market is not repricing an oil shock; it is repricing a central bank that decided to hike into one.

THE LEVELS · 23 SEPTEMBER CLOSE

US 10-year (par)	5.11%	▼ +15bp
US 10-year real (TIPS)	2.76%	▼ +13bp
VWRA (All-World)	193.62	▼ -0.69%
AGGU (global agg)	5.747	▼ -0.30%
Gold (Dec future /oz)	\$4,322.70	▼ -1.23%
Bitcoin	\$84,326	▼ -2.16%
Brent (front future)	\$98.36	▲ +3.09%

Par curve from the raw daily file, not a market close. The two-year rose 14bp to 4.85 and the dollar index 0.53 per cent to 101.13. Not advice.¹

Follow it through once. The EIA records **6.7 million barrels a day** of Middle East crude shut in during August, forecast at 5.7 for the fourth quarter. Dated Brent went from \$87.77 on 26 August to **\$130.80 on 15 September**. US headline inflation for August came in at **3.4 per cent** with energy up 16.3 and petrol up 27.4 — against **core at 2.4**. That is an energy wedge, not broad demand.²

The Fed hiked anyway: **25 basis points to 3¼–4 per cent on 16 September, unanimous**, the first rise since 2023, with the 2027 median dot up **fifty basis points** and unemployment revised *down*.³ Chairman Warsh gave the reason: “I would be hard-pressed to describe broad financial conditions as restrictive,” he said. “So we removed a dose of accommodation.”⁴

Then transmission. On Wednesday the ten-year par yield rose fifteen basis points to **5.11 per cent** — and the real yield rose **thirteen**, while the breakeven moved two. Roughly **87 per cent of the move was the price of real money**. The market does not think this an inflation regime. It thinks it a Fed regime.¹

+0.69

THE ONE-MONTH CORRELATION BETWEEN GLOBAL EQUITIES AND GLOBAL BONDS — THE HIGHEST OF THE ONE, THREE, SIX AND TWELVE-MONTH WINDOWS. IN NINETEEN OF THE LAST SIXTY-TWO SESSIONS BOTH FELL TOGETHER⁵

SOURCES 1 US Treasury daily par and real yield curves, read from the raw CSV for 2026, not the rendered table — which carries an extra “1.5 Month” column and shifts every reading one place. The 23 September row is reproduced exactly. Market levels from the Yahoo Finance chart endpoint for VWRA.L, AGGU.L, DX-Y.NYB, USDSGD=X, BZ=F, GC=F and BTC=USD. 2 US EIA, *Short-Term Energy Outlook*, 9 September, and the Europe Brent Spot Price FOB daily file (RBRTed.xls), re-pulled and marked against ICE front-month settlements; the dated-versus-future table is this desk’s own computation. 3 FOMC statement and Summary of Economic Projections, 16 September, both read at federalreserve.gov. 4 Transcript of Chairman Warsh’s press conference, 16 September. 5 Correlations computed here from daily returns on VWRA.L and AGGU.L over overlapping sessions. 6 BLS CPI release for August; US DOL weekly claims, 17 September; the US composite PMI print read at Trading Economics, since pmi.spglobal.com returned 403. 7 World Gold Council, *Gold Demand Trends* Q2 2026. 8 Bank of Japan, 18 September, with both dissents quoted from the Bank’s own note. This is market explanation and education, not investment advice.

Which is why the hedge is off. Bonds diversify equities when the shock is to growth; this one is to rates, so both sides of a sixty-forty are discounted by one rising number, and AGGU closed **0.07 per cent above its twelve-month low**. Call it **higher-for-longer, supply-shock variant**: with the composite PMI at **58.4** and claims at 196,000, a hot economy absorbing a cold supply shock.⁶

REAL-RATES-LED

DOLLAR BID

DIVERSIFICATION OFF

THE VERDICT · WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD AND BTC

One rising discount rate prices all four. Equities hold up on earnings; global aggregate bonds sit at a one-year low. Gold at **\$4,322.70** is **22.6 per cent below** its high despite a war and an oil shock, because 2.76 per cent real is a high hurdle for an asset that pays nothing — central banks bought 289 tonnes net last quarter, up 62 per cent, which is a floor rather than a bid. Bitcoin is **33.2 per cent below** its high while equities sit one per cent off theirs, and on Wednesday it gave back 2.16 per cent against the S&P’s 0.76 — about three times the beta to the same move. It trades liquidity, not risk appetite.⁷ Explanation, not advice.

THE SCEPTIC · AND ONE OF THE DISSENTERS IS INSIDE A CENTRAL BANK

Two of nine Bank of Japan board members voted against last Friday’s rise to around 1.25 per cent, and the Bank published their reasoning. **Asada Toichiro** argued that with core CPI below two per cent it “could not necessarily be said that the economic situation was strong”; **Sato Ayano**, that developments had not “substantially accelerated.”⁸ That is the argument aimed at the Fed, made by voting members and printed by the institution. And the shock is resolving: dated Brent is **\$15.91 off** its peak, and the EIA’s own forecast has \$77 by mid-2027. A Fed left restrictive into a disinflation is the risk nobody is pricing.²

HELD FROM NO. 111 — ANSWERED, AND FLIPPED

THE INVITATION · SOURDOUGH AND HOME BREAD BAKING

The wild yeast in your jar is mostly the same yeast you can buy in a packet

Five hundred starters were sequenced. In 77 per cent of them the commercial baker's yeast species was over half the fungal reads — and geography predicted nothing at all.

Commercial baking uses one organism doing one job. A sourdough starter is a two-kingdom ecosystem — wild yeasts plus lactic acid bacteria — kept alive indefinitely by backslopping, which is the unglamorous word for keeping a spoonful of the old to seed the new. In a mature starter the bacteria run at roughly **10⁸ colony-forming units a gram** and the yeasts one or two logarithmic cycles lower: ten to a hundred bacteria for every yeast, not the flat hundred-to-one of folklore. Over **ninety LAB species** have been isolated from sourdoughs worldwide; any one backslopped jar settles on a handful.¹

Then the Rob Dunn lab sequenced five hundred of them — 429 American, 29 Canadian, 24 European, 17 Australasian, one Thai, which makes the project's "global" oversold and worth saying. Median per starter: **seven bacterial and thirty-five fungal variants**. And the finding that punctures the romance: ***Saccharomyces cerevisiae* — the species in the packet — was over half the fungal reads in 77 per cent of samples.**²

<10%

OF VARIATION IN COMMUNITY COMPOSITION EXPLAINED BY FEEDING FLOUR, SCHEDULE AND AGE COMBINED.

GEOGRAPHY PREDICTED NOTHING. THE SAN FRANCISCO AIR DOES NOT MAKE THE SAN FRANCISCO SOURDOUGH²

The paper's novel passenger was the acetic acid bacteria — previously overlooked, in about a fifth of starters, **negatively correlated with rise rate** at $p = -0.51$ and positively with vinegar aromas. If your starter smells sharp and rises slowly, you may be hosting something nobody used to look for.²

The gateway is not in doubt. King Arthur sold over **156 million pounds of flour in 2020**, up 58 per cent, with recipe searches up 460 per cent; in March alone

flour sales rose over 2,000 per cent, and the shortage was never wheat — it was bagging capacity for five-pound retail bags. How much stuck is the better question, and the honest answer is the company's own: baking settled **25 to 30 per cent above 2019**, not 58.³

THE CHATTER · THE COMMUNITY KEPT GROWING AFTER THE FLOUR RAN OUT

Reddit refused this build on every path, so these are third-party trackers, not Reddit. **r/Sourdough: 764,000 members, up 19.2 per cent year on year — 123,000 people** — snapshot 20 September. **r/Breadit: 1.3 million, up 11.8 per cent.** The flair analysis tells you the culture better than the count: the two most-used post flairs on the sourdough forum are "1st Sourdough Ever - be kind" and "Starter help". It is a beginner-dominant, crumb-review culture, and its most-reviewed product category is Dutch ovens.⁴

THE SCEPTIC · AND IN THE SHOPS, THE WORD MEANS NOTHING AT ALL

UK supermarket sourdough grew **56 per cent by volume** in the year to July, with sourdough focaccia up 141 per cent and "sourdoughnuts" up 172.⁵ None of it has to be sourdough. Defra's guidance of 23 April 2025 **created no legal definition**; the word is governed only by the general rule that a name must not mislead. The Real Bread Campaign's coordinator **Chris Young** illustrates the gap: a product made with "emulsifiers, artificial preservative, baker's yeast and inert sourdough powder" can still be labelled sourdough provided the ingredients list discloses it. The industry's own proposed code would permit "sourdough with...", "sourdough style" and "sourdough flavour" on exactly such bread; Young calls it "a small number of companies seeking to profit from legitimising using the word sourdough in ways they see fit." Over a thousand bakers signed a call to withdraw support. France settled this by decree in 1993.⁶

WHAT THE NEXT TWO PAGES DESCEND INTO

SOURCES 1 Pérez-Alvarado et al., "Role of lactic acid bacteria and yeasts in sourdough fermentation during breadmaking," *Frontiers in Microbiology*, 2022 — read at source for the CFU ratio and the ninety-species figure. Note the 2020 taxonomy: the canonical *Lactobacillus sanfranciscensis* is now *Fructilactobacillus sanfranciscensis*, after Zheng et al. split the genus into twenty-five. 2 Landis, Oliverio, McKenney et al., "The diversity and function of sourdough starter microbiomes," *eLife*, 26 January 2021, DOI 10.7554/eLife.61644 — read at source; sample composition, medians, read shares, the *S. cerevisiae* finding, the acetic-acid-bacteria correlation and the variance figure all from the paper. 3 World Bakers, 10 March 2021, reporting King Arthur's own figures and co-CEO Karen Colberg's 25–30 per cent line; the March 2020 and bagging-capacity details are from the collated pandemic-baking record rather than the underlying trade reports. 4 Gummysearch's trackers for r/Sourdough and r/Breadit, read 20–21 September 2026; reddit.com and old.reddit.com both refused. 5 NIQ and Circana figures as reported by the UK baking trade press; British Baker returned 405 and two US grocery titles 403, so the full articles were not read and the figures are attributed rather than verified. 6 Sustain / Real Bread Campaign, its bread-labelling page last updated 31 March 2026 and its news item of 6 February 2023, both read at source; Defra's 23 April 2025 guidance as analysed there.

THE DEEP END · WHERE THEY GATHER, AND WHAT THEY FIGHT ABOUT

Nine arguments, four schools, and one of the community's pillars is now a shop

Sourdough.com redirects to a retail site. The Fresh Loaf still has a fifteen-year archive, which is why almost every argument in this craft can be sourced to a specific evening in 2018.

Start with the map. **The Fresh Loaf** is the elder statesman — forum plus member blogs, active since the mid-2000s, no public member count, and a named cast (trailrunner, Benito, alfanso, dabrownman, clazar123, Mini Oven, pmccool) who mentor to a fault. **King Arthur** is the institutional voice, employee-owned, running a Baker's Hotline and an explicitly anti-dogmatic posture: "there are as many ways to create, nurture, and bake with a starter as there are bakers in the world." **Sourdough.com** is gone as a forum; the domain now redirects to a shop.¹

The agenda-setters divide into four schools. The **Tartine open-crumb school** wants high hydration and a wildly irregular glossy crumb. The **data-driven school** — Kleinwächter's Bread Code, 340,000 subscribers and a 250-page book free under CC BY-SA at 500,000 monthly downloads, plus Cucuzza's fifty hours of ad-free video — holds that bread is a function of measurable variables. The **Real Bread traditionalists** treat sourdough as a definition to defend. And the **just-make-bread reaction**, led by Ben Starr: no levain, no autolyse, no folds, no banneton, no preheat, no discard.²

150% in 15h

CUCUZZA'S MEASURED RISE TEST-DRIVING STARR'S TEN-MINUTE METHOD AGAINST ITS CLAIMED TWENTY-FOUR HOURS, AT 22°C. HIS VERDICT: IT "GOES TOO FAR IN SACRIFICING QUALITY FOR EFFICIENCY"³

Two of the nine arguments earn their ink because the folk wisdom is wrong. **Stiff versus liquid starter**: stiff is supposed to be sourer, and Janjigian says it is backwards — stiff favours yeast over bacteria, making *milder* bread. **Autolyse**: the word no longer describes what it was coined for, and the benefit claimed is extensibility, not leavening.⁴

And the **Dutch oven**, the most conclusive argument here because someone ran it. In November 2023 a Fresh Loaf member baked one dough in a Dutch oven

and a steam oven: the Dutch-oven loaf threw a dramatic ear, the stone-baked one sealed its own score and looked "a bit unimpressive if truth be told." Another named the mechanism — convection fans keep running in steam mode and carry moisture off the surface. **The Dutch oven wins not because it is good at steam but because a domestic oven is bad at holding it.**⁵

THE CHATTER · THE OPEN-CRUMB WAR, 2018, AND THE LINE THAT ENDED IT

The thread was titled "**Open Crumb Fraudery**", and it accused Wilson's book of selling unachievable results. The forum rounded on the poster — "Some people just aren't good bakers" (**dabrownman**); "Persist. Practice. Patience. Don't be afraid to make birdfood!" (**clazar123**) — but the best line came from the other direction. **alfanso**, 25 June 2018: "**large holes are greatly overrated. You can't eat them.**" A year later another member named the phenomenon: "**the Instagram crumb fetish**", compared explicitly to unhealthy body comparison.⁶

THE SCEPTIC · DISCARD IS A PROBLEM PEOPLE MANUFACTURE

A hundred-gram starter fed daily throws away **25g of flour a day — about 9.1kg a year**, roughly \$21 at housebrand prices, and a content genre exists to absorb it. The forums carry the sharper self-criticism. **Ambimom**, twelve years in: "I don't discard it. I use it to make my bread." **MrBytchy**: "one I find confusing is the need people have to discard any starter". **Most discard is generated by keeping a bigger starter than you need**, and the recipe economy monetises a problem better maintenance would delete.⁷

THE GLOSSARY

Levain the starter built up for today's loaf · **bulk ferment** the first and longest rise, where loaves are won or lost · **bassinage** water held back to add after gluten forms · **poolish**, **biga** pre-ferments made with commercial yeast — neither is sourdough · **lame** a razor on a stick, said "lahm" · **retard** slowing fermentation by cooling · **hooch** the grey liquor on a hungry starter · **sourfaux** bread sold as sourdough, leavened with yeast.⁸

SOURCES 1 thefreshloaf.com, read at source for the live threads and the named regulars; kingarthurbaking.com's sourdough guide, quoted verbatim; shop.sourdough.com, which is where sourdough.com now redirects. 2 the-bread-code.io and the-sourdough-framework.com for the subscriber, page, licence and download figures; thesourdoughjourney.com for the video archive; ultimatefoodgeek.com for Starr's method as published. 3 Tom Cucuzza, The Sourdough Journey, November 2023, quoted verbatim from his own test-drive write-up. 4 Andrew Janjigian, "Stiffed," Wordloaf, 12 July 2023, and the Bread Code's starter-hydration experiment, both read at source; King Arthur's glossary for the autolyse definition. Raymond Calvel, to whom the technique is attributed, could not be read in a primary source. 5 The Fresh Loaf thread of 6 November 2023, quoted as posted. 6 The Fresh Loaf, "Open Crumb Fraudery," 24–25 June 2018, and the lamination thread of September 2019 — all quotations as posted. 7 The Fresh Loaf, "Why discard starter," March 2019 and March 2021; the flour arithmetic is this desk's, from FairPrice housebrand prices. 8 Definitions from King Arthur's glossary and The Sourdough School's, with Janjigian's wording for bassinage.

THE GEAR, THE TROPICS, AND THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Every tier above the entry point is an oven-and-steam purchase in a different hat

A Dutch oven is not a baking vessel; it is four litres of sealed space and some mass under the base. Once you know that, the ladder reprices — and here the constraint is not heat at all.

The hierarchy first. A scale matters more than a mixer, because bread is a ratio problem before it is a mechanical one: a five-gram salt error on a kilogram of flour is half a percentage point and visibly changes fermentation. **0.1g resolution is the entry requirement, not a luxury.** A mixer replaces labour, not judgement. The real ceiling is the oven — low deck mass, and a vent that evacuates steam as fast as you make it.¹

US\$294

THE WHOLE QUALITY ENTRY BENCH: A 0.1G SCALE AT \$24.95, A BENCH KNIFE, A CANE BANNETON, A WIRE MONKEY LAME AT \$36.95, A RUN-OUT THERMAPEN ONE AT \$74, A **LODGE COMBO COOKER AT \$59.90** AND A YARD OF FLAX LINEN²³

The mid tier buys capacity: the **Challenger at US\$299** takes a bâtard where the Lodge caps a boule near 750g. The high end is spiral mixers, where the decision is electrical. **Famag's Grilletta IM-5S/230 at €1,001** is a native 230-volt machine with a Schuko plug — the only high-end spiral here electrically correct for a Singapore flat out of the box. Sunmix's US-channel machines are 110 volts, and stepping down a 370-watt inverter motor voids the warranty. Buying the American version into Singapore is the most expensive avoidable mistake here.⁴

Over the top sits the **Rofco B20 at €1,865** — three decks, 2.5kW, 56kg — with **no South-East Asian distributor**. The genuine cutting edge of the last twelve months is narrower than the marketing: two categories moved. **Active cooling** arrived — Brød & Taylor's Proofer Pro, 2 April, US\$999, 5 to 50°C on 100–240 volts, and the Sourdough Home Plus, 14 September, US\$179. In a thirty-degree kitchen that is the first real retarding option short of clearing a fridge shelf.⁵

THE CHATTER · THE ENDGAME PURCHASE PEOPLE REGRET

On Anova's own forum, about its US\$999 steam oven: **Fedupflyer**, December 2025 — “The oven will not work without the tank inserted and water above a level — these are two new and ridiculous points of failure.” Neighbouring thread titles: “My APO died after only 3 years”, “Dead after 3.5 years”. Rofco owners report seals lasting ten to twelve months and doors that “will go in a concave shape” after a year — though a B20 owner rebuts the criticism: “if I am not happy with the result I think it is mainly down to me as a baker and not the oven!!!”⁶

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE SPENDING STOPS BUYING BREAD

semolina_man, The Fresh Loaf, December 2020: “If commercial bakeries aren't filled with Dutch ovens and people manipulating them, it's a clue... are Dutch ovens a myth? It's likely.” The numbers back him: the steam mechanism costs **US\$59.90** in a Lodge, **US\$204** in a Steel and Shell, or **US\$299** in twenty pounds of Challenger — and the man who owns the Challenger found the difference insignificant. Everything above buys capacity, not a better loaf.³⁶

THE TROPICAL ASTERISK

Every recipe you will read was written for a 20–24°C room. Changi's daily maximum is 30.6–32.4°C at about 82 per cent humidity. The rule the tropical threads hang on, from 2018: “just cut the time in half.” Target a **25°C dough**, inoculate at about ten per cent, keep the starter stiff, and treat the fridge as infrastructure. And do not bake on day seven.⁷⁸

NEXT DESCENTS — PICK TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Letterpress printing — Vandercook proofs, polymer against lead, and the Briar Press classifieds.

Lapidary & gem cutting — faceting machines, buying rough, and the meetpoint school.

Weaving & floor looms — the four-shaft threshold, and why the loom outlives the weaver.

SOURCES 1 The mechanism is this desk's, from the sources below; the steam and thermal-mass argument follows Andrew Janjigian's measurements. 2 Every price read at the maker's or retailer's own live page during this build: brodandtaylor.com, sourhouse.co, wiremonkey.com, thermoworks.com (Thermopen NANO published 18 August 2026; the ONE on colour closeout), lodgecastiron.com, shop-sfbi.myshopify.com. 3 Andrew Janjigian, “Toast in the Shell,” Wordloaf, 17 December 2024, quoted verbatim, with the weights as he gives them. 4 challengerbreadware.com, which offers no international shipping; America's Test Kitchen's cast-iron bread-oven review; AgriEuro for the Famag prices, VAT included, and famagsrl.it for the maker's own voltage and plug; sunmixusa.com and Pizzagoods for the 110-volt specification. 5 rofco.be's own specification page and its price list PDF, and its distributor list, which carries no South-East Asian entry; brodandtaylor.com for both 2026 listings and the 100–240-volt rating. 6 Anova's own community forum and The Fresh Loaf's Rofco threads, all quoted as posted. 7 Meteorological Service Singapore's Changi 1991–2020 reference figures; The Fresh Loaf's tropical-starter threads of 2018 and April 2025; Culinary Exploration for the dough-temperature and inoculation numbers. 8 King Arthur Baking, 17 August 2026, on the starter “fake out”, and The Sourdough Journey on cutting hot.

INTENSITY

Twelve minutes

In 147,414 accelerometer-wearing adults, twelve minutes a week of genuinely hard effort matched the mortality signal of a hundred and fifty minutes of moderate. Swapping an hour of pottering for an hour of hard work was worth up to thirty per cent.

One warning before the numbers, because the trap is set. This study's **n is 147,414**. The Harvard strength-training analysis this desk ran in No. 111 had **147,374**. They are different studies — that one was self-reported strength training, this one is device-measured intensity pooling the German National Cohort and UK Biobank. Nobody should quietly correct one into the other.¹

The design: prospective pooled cohort, hip-worn ActiGraph in Germany and wrist-worn Axivity AX3 in Britain, both at 100Hz over seven consecutive days with at least 72 hours of valid wear; adults 40 to 74; mean follow-up **7.9 years**, 1,170,697 person-years, 5,545 deaths. Observational, and the authors state it precludes causal inference.¹

The anchor is unchanged: **150 minutes a week of moderate activity against none gives a hazard ratio of 0.70**, interval 0.67 to 0.72. The equivalences are the news. About **510 minutes of light**, or about **twelve minutes of vigorous**, sat at the same mortality reduction. The lowest vigorous category in the data — **two to twenty minutes a week** — already showed 0.66.¹

18–30%

LOWER MORTALITY FROM REALLOCATING 15 TO 60 MINUTES A WEEK OF LIGHT ACTIVITY TO VIGOROUS, WITH **TOTAL ACTIVE TIME HELD CONSTANT**. LIGHT TO MODERATE GAVE 3 TO 11 PER CENT¹

That substitution analysis is the useful part, because it holds the hour fixed. The gain came from changing *what* the hour was, not from finding a new one. In the authors' own words: "modest shifts toward higher-intensity movement provide additional benefit."¹

THE CHATTER · THE LONGEVITY CROWD IS ARGUING ABOUT ZONE 2, AND THIS LANDS IN IT

Dr Samuel Choudhury, a Singapore family physician, put the efficiency case in May: "The most efficient longevity training in the general population is not 45 minutes of easy cycling four times a week." His prescription is an eighty-twenty easy-to-hard split, one weekly four-by-four session, two strength sessions and an annual VO2max test, citing Storoschuk's 2025 review that work-matched higher intensity equals or beats Zone 2 for mitochondrial adaptation.² Worth a date stamp on the community's anchor: Peter Attia's canonical VO2max-and-mortality page rests on Mandsager 2018 and was published in 2022. It is the reference point, not new. His own podcast's centre of gravity has moved to early lipid lowering and peptide scepticism.³

THE SCEPTIC · A NAMED GROUP IS ARGUING THE OTHER SIDE, THIS MONTH

Stephanie Prince of the Public Health Agency of Canada, with **Ulf Ekelund**, **Emmanuel Stamatakis**, **Paddy Dempsey** and colleagues, published a call to action in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine* on 16 August making the direct counter-case. Light activity is **51 to 59 per cent** of daily activity energy expenditure, and **most adults spend under five per cent of the day** at moderate or above — so intensity-efficiency arguments optimise a sliver. Verbatim: light activity "accounts for most daily movement and energy expenditure, offers the most feasible lever for population-level change." Replacing thirty minutes a day of sitting with light activity ran at 2 to 16 per cent lower cardiovascular risk. Print the competing interest: Stamatakis holds equity in a company whose products relate to promoting physical activity.⁴ And the lead paper concedes its own weakest joint — cut-point uncertainty. "Vigorous" is a milli-g threshold that differs between a hip and a wrist.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO — BUILT ONLY FROM WHAT THESE SOURCES SUPPORT

SOURCES 1 Stein MJ et al., "Intensity-specific physical activity and mortality in 147,414 adults: a pooled accelerometer analysis," *Int J Behav Nutr Phys Act* 23(1), September 2026, DOI 10.1186/s12966-026-01980-3 — full open-access text read via the Europe PMC XML endpoint, since europepmc.org and link.springer.com both refused. Every hazard ratio, interval and equivalence above is from it, as is the closing quotation and the cut-point caveat. Funders include the World Cancer Research Fund, Wellcome, the MRC and the Helmholtz and Leibniz Associations; one author discloses industry consulting. 2 Dr Samuel Choudhury, 11 May 2026, quoted verbatim. 3 peterattiamd.com, page dated 17 May 2022, and the podcast archive read for the last six weeks' episodes. 4 Prince SA, Chaput J-P, Colley RC, Dempsey PC, Ekelund U, Janssen I, Lang JJ, Stamatakis E, Tarp J, Tremblay MS et al., *Br J Sports Med* 60(16), published online 16 August 2026, DOI 10.1136/bjsports-2025-111179 — full text read via Europe PMC; bjsm.bmj.com returned 403. Competing interest as printed. 5 Bagheri R, Ghobadi H, Mansordegghani M, Camera DM, Kargarfarid M, *J Int Soc Sports Nutr*, online 14 September 2026, DOI 10.1080/15502783.2026.2720742 — read via the Europe PMC core record. Funding not stated in the record available.

THE AGENDA · TWO THINGS CLOSE BEFORE OCTOBER

Book now, plan ahead

Marathon entries shut on the 30th and the Sugimoto closes on the 4th. Everything else here was re-verified at the promoter, the venue or the official box office this morning.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

9–11
Oct

Singapore Grand Prix — the first sprint weekend

MARINA BAY · ZONE 4 WALKABOUT FROM \$198, TURN 1 FROM \$1,698; PREMIUM TIERS SOLD OUT. THE 09:00 SATURDAY SPRINT IS THE HUMANE OPTION WITH A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD.¹

7
OCT

Hans Zimmer Live — The Next Level

INDOOR STADIUM, 19:00 · \$148–\$468 · NEW *DUNE* AND *INTERSTELLAR* ARRANGEMENTS. UNDER-THREES REFUSED.²

4
OCT

Hiroshi Sugimoto: Form Is Emptiness — closes

SINGAPORE ART MUSEUM · \$15 RESIDENTS, \$20 VISITORS · FREE CLOSING-DAY TALKS. THE MUSEUM'S OWN SITE CARRIES TWO DATES; GO THIS WEEKEND.³

21
Oct–
1 Nov

37th Singapore International Film Festival

MULTIPLE VENUES · PROGRAMME AND PRICES UNPUBLISHED; IT HAS MOVED OUT OF ITS LATE-NOVEMBER SLOT.⁴

7–8
Nov

PokéXciting! Singapore + Pokémon RUN 30

CHANGI T3 AND JEWEL; RUN AT STADIUM ROAR · FESTIVAL ZONE **FREE**, RUN PAID, PRE-REGISTRATION ONLY · ALL 27 FIRST-PARTNER POKÉMON THROUGH FOREST VALLEY.⁵

10–13
Dec

PGL Major Singapore 2026 — playoffs

INDOOR STADIUM · \$144 TO \$369 BY DAY · 32 TEAMS, US\$1.25M POOL, INSIDE THE DECEMBER SCHOOL HOLIDAYS.²

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

to 13
Dec

Renaissance masterpieces from the Louvre

NATIONAL ART CENTER, TOKYO · ADVANCE ¥2,200 · **TIMED ENTRY IS IMPOSED ONLY FOR 7–13 DECEMBER** — GO BEFORE THEN AND YOU WALK IN.⁶

28
Oct–
8 Feb

Shojo Manga Infinity: Hagio, Yamagishi, Yamato

NATIONAL ART CENTER · ADVANCE ¥2,000, **FREE FOR FIFTEEN AND UNDER** — THE THREE ARCHITECTS OF POSTWAR SHŌJO MANGA, AND THE BEST VALUE HERE.⁶

31
Oct–
28 Mar

Mariko Mori: All That Shines

MORI ART MUSEUM · WEEKDAY ¥2,800, ¥2,600 ONLINE, WEEKEND ¥3,000; JUNIOR-HIGH AND UNDER FREE. ONLINE ON A WEEKDAY SAVES ¥400 A HEAD.⁷

10–24
Jan

Grand Sumo, Hatsu basho

RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN · **ADVANCE TICKETS 5 DECEMBER, 10:00 JST**, ALWAYS A SATURDAY. DIARISE IT: NOVEMBER'S KYUSHU BASHO IS ALREADY "SOLD OUT ALL DATES".⁸

28
NOV

Niseko opens — 2026/27 season

NISEKO UNITED · ALL MOUNTAIN PASS ¥184,400 ADULT, ¥110,600 AGE 4–12; NIGHT SKIING FROM 12 DECEMBER. EARLY, AND IT MOVES WITH THE SNOW.⁹

4–11
Feb

77th Sapporo Snow Festival

ODORI, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME · NO PRICE PUBLISHED AT SOURCE, SO NONE PRINTED. SOME OUTLETS CALL THIS THE 78TH; IT IS THE 77TH.¹⁰

to 10
Jan

Design Ah! at M+, Hong Kong

M+ MAIN HALL GALLERY · PRICE NOT PUBLISHED ON THE LISTINGS PAGE · THE BEST FAMILY SHOW IN HONG KONG, AND IT DIES ON 10 JANUARY. *MYTHS AND MONSTERS* OPENS 17 OCTOBER IN THE SAME BUILDING.¹¹

PLANNING NOTES · AND ONE LIVE WARNING

Closing this week: marathon entries end **30 September**, and note the rebrand — no longer the Standard Chartered; the Sugimoto ends 4 October; the Writers Festival programme lands 29 September with its early-bird passes already gone.

Held for want of a primary source: Christmas Wonderland, where an aggregator gives 27 November to 3 January and the Gardens' own calendar carries no Christmas listing at all. *Moulin Rouge!* is a February 2027 line with no dates ever published; ZoukOut was dropped because the reporting contradicts itself. Then the warning that explains why the still-on check exists: **the Kallang's own events index still carries a live page for a cancelled Post Malone stadium date.** The venue site is stale. It is not listed here, and should not be listed anywhere.¹¹

SOURCES 1 formulal.com's 2026 Singapore schedule and singaporegp.sg's own ticket page, including its sold-out flags. 2 thekallang.com.sg, the venue's own event page. 3 singaporeartmuseum.sg, read as raw HTML; the site carries conflicting closing dates and 4 October is the one printed. 4 sgiff.com; the reported Kore-eda honour and a 24 October premiere appear only in one secondary report and are not printed. 5 sg.portal-pokemon.com, the official Pokémon Asia 30th-anniversary page, with thekallang.com.sg for the run. 6 nact.jp's English exhibition pages for both Tokyo shows, including the 7–13 December timed-entry note. 7 mori.art.museum, including the online-weekday differential. 8 sumo.pia.jp, the association's own ticket platform, and sumo.or.jp for the sold-out notice; the association's own schedule paths currently return a URL error, so Pia is the working primary. 9 en.grand-hirafu.jp for the season dates, which move with the snow, and niseko.ne.jp for the pass prices. 10 snowfes.com's Japanese homepage, which gives 4–11 February and the 77th edition; the English page is stale and still shows 2025. 11 singaporeinternationalmarathon.com for the 30 September registration deadline and the rebrand; singaporewritersfestival.com for the 29 September programme date and the sold-out early-bird tiers. Events dropped from this page for want of a primary source are named in the planning notes rather than listed.

THE TABLE · FOUR ROOMS, THREE VERDICTS

Three of these have been eaten in and scored. The most expensive has not.

A hundred-and-eighteen-dollar afternoon tea that no named reviewer has publicly assessed six weeks after opening is not an oversight. At this point it is the finding.

Kimpson's Table is the one to go to, and the least announced. It arrived at Far East Square in September as a room after a year as a home-based delivery pop-up — no launch event, just a counter at the Telok Ayer exit. Chef Patrick Kim cooks Korean *hansang* from his mother's and grandmother's recipes: samgyetang at **\$18**, dak bibim kalguksu at \$15, snow-cheese fried chicken at \$17, almost nothing over twenty dollars. Walk-in at lunch, reservations at dinner.¹

And it has been eaten in properly, which on this page is rarer than it sounds. The Ranting Panda scored it **4 out of 5** — taste 4, value 3, ambience 3 — calling the samgyetang's flavour “clear and clean” and the fried chicken “sinfully good”, with two reservations: the bibim kalguksu is “quite spicy”, and the seating produces a CBD lunch queue. Three further outlets filed sit-down pieces rather than previews. **Genuinely liked, and under-publicised.**¹

Kappo Suguru is the other end of the price ladder and the same standard of evidence: a counter-only kappo room at 192 Joo Chiat Road, run by chef Desmond on a shophouse-share arrangement — three days a week, a sushiya the rest. Omakase from **S\$180++**, the reviewed eleven-course menu **S\$250++**. The signature is tallow-aged A5 wagyu grilled at the counter, which the review calls “biblical levels of buttery, melt-in-your-mouth richness”. **4 out of 5**, with the layout named as the limit: no larger groups, and book well ahead.²

THE BUZZ · THE ONE PLACE WHERE A REVIEWER SAID WHAT DID NOT WORK

Noor, 17 Mohamed Sultan Road, is a 65-seat Mediterranean room with Japanese seams — tahini and harissa over yuzu and miso, a shawarma gyoza — from co-owner Titus Thamil. Small plates \$16 to \$26, large \$25 to \$68. MiddleClass split the menu down the middle: the **Muhammara Miso** was “the standout” and the ebi freekeh risotto their favourite hot dish, “layered, herby and creamy” — but the Mediterranean ramen “lacked in flavour”, and the maguro crispy rice wanted its tartare cold. That is what a filed review looks like. Its opening month is contested across three outlets, so no date is printed.³

TOO NEW TO CALL · AND AFTER SIX WEEKS, THAT IS THE VERDICT

Rituel, Tokyo's *salon de thé* and boulangerie, opened at Takashimaya on **11 August** after a July soft launch: a 36-layer croissant slow-fermented overnight, an escargot danish, and a **\$118++** afternoon tea. Five outlets filed on the soft launch and every word reads as preview — **no rating, no verdict, no negative note, no queue reporting anywhere**. Desserts went reservation-only from mid-August, the only scarcity signal on record. A hundred-and-eighteen-dollar tea nobody has publicly assessed is the likeliest disappointment here, however good the croissant.⁴

TWO PEGS CARRIED FORWARD, AND ONE CLOSED

Why this page skips the month's obvious openings. Seven of the strongest September candidates ran in Nos. 110 and 111, and a venue's second appearance waits at least seven issues — the rule adopted after a reader counted one restaurant appearing four times in thirteen editions. One further candidate was cut on verification: it opened in 2024, under a different chef.

And the Ebisu hamburg house is still held. It soft-launched at Lau Pa Sat on 22 September, grand opening 5 October — and the piece carrying a first-person verdict was **published on the 21st, the day before**. A media preview tasting, not a review of an operating restaurant; it rolls to No. 113. Whuchu's peg, open since No. 90, can finally close: a filed review with ratings landed on 5 September — taste 3.5, value 4 — praising the salt-aged Jeju pork and calling a \$16 minari pancake “bland”. Solid, not special.⁵

SOURCES 1 The Ranting Panda's review of 17 August 2026, quoted verbatim including its component scores, with corroborating sit-down pieces at Eatbook, Honeycombers and MiddleClass; prices and the walk-in policy read at those sources. 2 The Ranting Panda, 2 September 2026, quoted verbatim with its scores; the shophouse-share arrangement and the two menu prices as published there. 3 MiddleClass's review, quoted verbatim in both directions; prices from the same piece. Its opening month is given variously as July, August and September by Eatbook, TheSmartLocal and Honeycombers, so none is printed. 4 Eatbook, Time Out Singapore and three further outlets, all filed on the soft launch; the absence of an assessed verdict is the finding, not an omission from this page. 5 HungryGoWhere, 21 September, whose publication date precedes the soft launch by a day; The Ranting Panda, 5 September, for the Whuchu ratings. Burpple returned 403 on every fetch and Reddit refused, so no diner-forum sentiment is asserted anywhere on this page.

THE UNDERCURRENT · KAZAKHSTAN

Лудомания

Kazakhstan can tell you the names of the hundred and thirty-five thousand people it stopped from placing a bet this spring. It cannot tell you how many of its citizens are ill to within two orders of magnitude.

The word is **лудомания** — *ludomaniya*, play-madness, from the Latin for a game and the Greek for a frenzy. It is not a phrase meaning gambling addiction. It is a single diagnostic noun that has become the organising word of Kazakh public life: it names government decrees, hospital protocols, parliamentary inquiries, a fatwa, and a whole genre of confession video. The native Kazakh alternative, *ойынқұмарлық*, exists and loses.¹

It began on a stage in Atyrau. At the National Kurultai on **15 March 2024** President Tokayev named ludomania one of five social evils — “Ludomania brings immeasurable harm, destroying thousands of families, driving many to crime” — put the number of regular gamblers at around four hundred thousand, and demanded a law before the session closed. He got one by July. Decree No. 432 followed with a plan: twenty-eight measures, a target of **350,000 down to 201,600** by the end of 2026, and a budget of **80,931,200 tenge**, about a hundred and fifty thousand dollars.²

Roughly one Kazakh adult in four is now legally barred from betting because of what they owe.

Enforcing it required plumbing, and the plumbing is the story. Since September 2024 it has been illegal for certain citizens to place a bet at all: anyone under twenty-one, any serving civil servant, soldier or police officer, anyone with a criminal conviction, anyone owing child maintenance — and, the radical provision, **anyone listed on the Unified Register of Debtors, some 3.5 million people** in a country of 20.6 million.³

On **27 March 2026** the ECV went live — the *Yedinaya sistema uchota*, the Unified Accounting System. Every licensed bookmaker must integrate with it. Every deposit and withdrawal routes through it. And every

bet is checked, before it is accepted, against the debtors’ register, the self-exclusion register, the civil-service roll and the age record. In parallel, banks were obliged from January to detect and block transfers to unlicensed platforms from a state blacklist of **110 foreign payment providers**; from May, telecoms operators had to block casino payments taken against mobile balances.⁴

This is enforcement at the granularity of the individual, in real time, at national scale — which no Western gambling regulator can approach. Answering parliament on **1 July**, Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov gave the first numbers: between 27 March and 7 June the system identified about **433,000 users** and blocked **135,000** — over 116,000 debt defaulters, over 15,000 self-excluded, some 4,000 otherwise. It also detected **62,000 illegal internet casinos**.⁴

Hold those two sentences next to each other, because they are the argument. The state stopped a hundred and thirty-five thousand named individuals from betting in ten weeks. In the same ten weeks it found sixty-two thousand places where they could go instead.

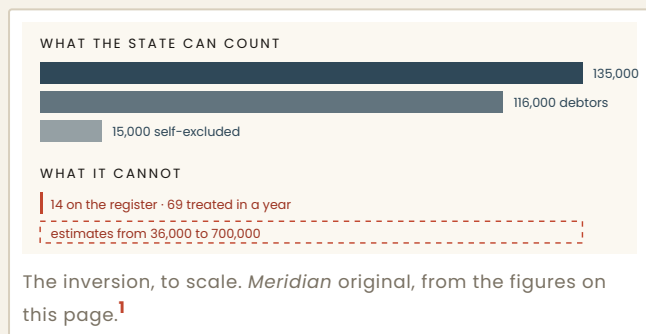
It can find them all instantly — if “them” is defined as a row in a debt register.

Kazakhstan is not an outlier in appetite. It is an outlier in capability. Household internet access runs at **97.1 per cent**; there are **26.5 million mobile subscriptions** against 20.6 million people; a national identity number keys every register; and a single super-app carries much of retail payment. A state so equipped *can* enforce behavioural rules at the identity layer — and that capability is arriving everywhere.⁵

SOURCES 1 Etymology and usage confirmed at rpsauran.kz, the state mental-health centre network, and in the Spiritual Administration’s own fatwa text; Kazakh Wikipedia’s article is titled Лудомания, which confirms the loanword’s dominance over the native term. 2 Tokayev’s address to the third session of the National Kurultai, 15 March 2024, read at akorda.kz and quoted in translation. Decree No. 432 of 2024 — adilet.zan.kz serves the text only through an authenticated API returning 401, so the twenty-eight measures, the 350,000-to-201,600 target and the 80,931,200-tenge budget are as reported by 24.kz, Kazpravda and Nur.kz, not read in the decree itself. 3 Senator Nurtore Zhusip on the scope of the bar, via inbusiness.kz; population 20,590,589 at 1 July 2026 from the Bureau of National Statistics. 4 Prime Minister Olzhas Bektenov’s reply to parliamentary inquiries, reported 1 July 2026 by Kursiv; the banking and telecoms obligations and the 110-provider blacklist from Tengrinews and Lada.kz citing government. 5 Khamzina & Buribayev, *Frontiers in Psychology*, 26 August 2026, for the penetration, subscription and microfinance series.

Now the other column of numbers, and it is where the state goes quiet. How many Kazakhstanis actually have a gambling disorder? The official register said **eight** in 2023 and **fourteen** in mid-2024. The Ministry of Health said **36,000** in March 2025. The presidential speech said **400,000**. The Comprehensive Plan's operative baseline is **350,000**. A deputy told parliament in June it was **700,000**.¹

And the clinical record is smaller than any of them. The Ministry of Health counted **69 gambling-disorder hospitalisations in 2024** and 47 in the first half of 2025, with thirty people on outpatient monitoring at July 2025 — up from fifteen a year earlier. At the Republican Scientific-Practical Centre for Mental Health, roughly a quarter of about 130 beds were occupied by gambling cases, against fourteen patients on the official register. Its director, Kuanysh Altynbekov, has been explicit that the Centre replaced stigmatising “dynamic observation” with confidential “consultative observation” precisely to get people through the door.¹



Underneath the panic is a labour story that nobody is treating as one. The map of ludomania is not the map of wealth or of youth. It is the map of the oilfields — **Mangystau, Atyrau, Kyzylorda, West Kazakhstan, Aktoke**. The analyst Liliya Manshina lists the drivers plainly: a high proportion of shift employment, prolonged separation from family, stress, total digital accessibility. Men in their late twenties, paid in lumps, housed in camps, with a phone and nothing to do.²

The employers worked it out before the ministries did. KazMunayGas, which employed **21,805 people in Mangystau** alone last year, now plans psychologist

consultations *timed to payday*. In Atyrau region, **326 alimony defaulters moved over 800 million tenge** into gambling across four years. Mangystau also hosts over ninety per cent of the roughly hundred thousand IP addresses running illegal online casinos nationally; one operation pushed **3.1 billion tenge** through facilitator accounts in a single month. The oil region is both the demand and the supply. The Comprehensive Plan, meanwhile, trained 656 schoolteachers.³

Recovery is being attempted through prayer, because the clinical system treated sixty-nine people.

Which is why the most useful piece of research on this subject is an ethnography rather than a statistical series. Rustamjon Urinboyev of Lund, with Yermek Buribayev and Daniyar Kaldiyarov, ran twenty in-depth interviews and three fieldwork visits in Almaty between February and May 2025, and concluded that “gambling addiction should not be seen merely as an individual pathology but as a structural vulnerability embedded in digital capitalism and fragile governance”, with religion supplying “culturally embedded repertoires of resilience, often perceived as more effective than secular therapy”. The Council of Scholars ruled ludomania *haram* in November 2023. Their paper takes its title from a participant: prayer helps better than a psychologist.⁴

The market they are all describing is real and it is enormous. Gambling and betting turned over **592.2 billion tenge in 2025**, an absolute record and **thirty-eight times** its 2017 level. Online betting went from 34.8 to **370.5 billion tenge in one year** — from six per cent of the betting market to **62.6** — while land-based casino revenue fell sixteen per cent. Youth participation in regular gambling went from **0.1 per cent in 2021 to 6.3 per cent in 2024**, and the average problem gambler's debt exceeds twenty-two thousand US dollars.⁵

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Health figures via Azattyq Ruhy; Gulmira Sadvakasova and director Kuanysh Altynbekov of the Republican Scientific-Practical Centre for Mental Health, via inform.kz and inbusiness.kz, for the bed occupancy, the register count and the change in observation category. The spread of prevalence estimates is assembled from the presidential address, Decree No. 432's baseline as reported, ministry statements and a deputy's remarks to parliament — the divergence is the point, and each figure is attributed to its own claimant rather than reconciled. 2 Liliya Manshina, SPIK.kz, 15 July 2026, quoted in translation. 3 SPIK.kz, 17 September 2026, “Ludomania on the vakhta”, for the KazMunayGas headcount, the Atyrau defaulters, the facilitator flows and the payday counselling; Lada.kz (Aktau) for the IP-address concentration. 4 Urinboyev R, Buribayev Y, Kaldiyarov D, *Journal of Gambling Issues*, 3 November 2025, read as the published PDF and quoted verbatim; the fatwa of 10 November 2023 read at muftat.kz. 5 Finprom.kz, working from Bureau of National Statistics series, for the market and online-share figures; Khamzina & Buribayev, *Frontiers in Sociology*, 8 January 2026, for the youth participation and average-debt figures.

And the gate has a toll. A December 2024 resolution created a wholly state-owned operator; the payment processing went to **NomaPay**, incorporated in July 2024 — two months before the law took effect — with a single founder and **no open tender**. The system levies up to **1.5 per cent of all transactions** in a market the fintech industry puts above 1.2 trillion tenge a year.¹

Two sitting MPs allege capture. **Yermurat Bapi's** inquiry of October 2025 puts the cost at roughly **110 billion tenge a year in tax**; **Bakytzhan Bazarbek** argues the state system is a cover, its contracts with the processor marked “for official use only”. In early March the National Bank told payment organisations to stop processing for bookmakers; on the third and fourth, deposits and withdrawals broke at most major operators while one Russian-owned book kept running. The whole mechanism in one week — a public-health instrument that is also a private rent, enforced by cutting the pipes.²

Note where the public anger landed. Not on surveillance: the bettors’ trade press covered those March days as a consumer grievance — deposits dead, withdrawals dead, money stuck. A state that reads your debts before it reads your bet drew less complaint than a payment outage.³

Faulkner’s line, quoted on p2, is the whole of it: the past is never dead — it is not even past.

So here is the thesis. Kazakhstan has accidentally run the world’s cleanest experiment in governing by database, and the result is an inversion: **extraordinary precision of enforcement, and almost no capacity for knowledge or care**. This is not a Kazakh peculiarity but the near future of digital states, and the logic is just cost. When a state holds universal digital identity and a consolidated credit register, the cheapest public-health intervention available is **exclusion by database** — and it will always be chosen over diagnosis, treatment or redistribution, because it costs almost nothing and produces beautiful numbers. The plan was budgeted

at a hundred and fifty thousand dollars against a market of five hundred and ninety-two billion tenge. You cannot treat anyone for that. You can write an interface.

There is precedent for the shape of this, and it is instructive because it worked. Britain’s nineteenth-century public-health state took its victories from plumbing rather than medicine: the Public Health Act of 1875 and the sewers beneath it cut cholera without anyone treating a case, and before germ theory was settled. Enforcement outran understanding and still saved lives. The difference is the object. A sewer acts on water; a register acts on a person, and by a category — solvency — with nothing to do with the illness it nominally addresses.⁴

Kazakhstan has not banned gambling for the addicted. It has banned it for the indebted.

Those two sets overlap and are not the same, and the policy’s logic is fiscal and moral rather than clinical: you may gamble if you are solvent. Three and a half million people now carry a legal disability in consumption because of their balance sheet. Watch the principle spread. If a debtors’ register can gate betting, it can gate credit, travel, alcohol, procurement, a licence. Tokayev’s own framing at the Kurultai — *adal embek, adal tabys*, honest labour and honest income — is the moral grammar that makes it feel natural rather than novel.

Three things to watch. Whether the successor plan for 2027 to 2029 sets a prevalence target at all, or retreats to enforcement metrics — the tell that the state has given up on knowing. Whether the two inquiries force a re-tender. And whether Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan and Azerbaijan copy the architecture. If they do, Central Asia will have built the template for database-gated consumption before the West has debated it — and the four new foreigner-only gambling zones, one on the Mangystau coast that hosts ninety per cent of the illegal servers, will stand as the summary of the policy: prohibition for the indebted citizen, marketing for the tourist.⁵

SOURCES 1 Government Resolution No. 1087 of 20 December 2024 establishing the state operator, and the processing arrangement, as reported by bne IntelliNews and Gambling Insider from fintech-industry submissions, and by Orda.kz; the 1.5 per cent ceiling and the 1.2-trillion-tenge flow are the industry’s figures, not the state’s. 2 Yermurat Bapi’s parliamentary inquiry of 14 October 2025, via Orda.kz — which notes that no documentary evidence exists in Kazakhstan’s public registries for one of his alleged links, and that qualification is carried here; Bakytzhan Bazarbek via youth.kz. The March payment outage as reported by Legalbet.kz. 3 Legalbet.kz, read as a consumer complaint rather than a political one. 4 The Public Health Act 1875 and the sanitary movement’s chronology are given here only as far as the standard record supports: the Act consolidated earlier legislation, and London’s interceptory sewers were substantially complete before Koch isolated the cholera bacillus in 1884. 5 Ministerial order in force 17 May 2026 restricting the four new tourist gambling zones to foreigners and stateless persons; Mangystau’s Caspian zone established 21 July 2026, per Lada.kz. On the hook: the Ministry of Tourism and Sports published its implementation report on 4 September 2026, whose own prevalence research counts roughly 484,000 illegal-casino and 494,000 unlicensed-bookmaker users against a target of 201,600 — gov.kz returns only a platform shell to a fetcher, so that date and those figures are as reported and consistently indexed, not read at the ministry.

A sewer acts on water. A register acts on a person.

Both are plumbing, and both work before anybody understands the disease. That is the uncomfortable thing about the week's reading: almost every instrument in this issue was set by a window that had already shut. A tariff priced off April. A constitutional veto lost in a July vote by the party that would need it in September. A patent granted in 2020 without a search and enforced in 2026 after the same claims had been voided elsewhere. A benchmark score that describes a file nobody is running. A debt entered long before anyone placed a bet.

None of it is a failure of measurement. Each instrument measured exactly what it was built to measure, faithfully, at the moment it was read. The lag is not in the reading. It is in the gap between when a thing is decided and when it is felt — and that gap is where almost all of the consequence lives.

SOURCES, THIS EDITION Per-page source lines carry the full record; this is the consolidated list. **Primary documents and official releases:** the Verfassung des Landes Mecklenburg-Vorpommern (Landtag, April 2025 edition); the Landtag's and wahlrecht.de's preliminary official results and Statistik Berlin-Brandenburg's; OHCHR report A/HRC/63/61 (via mirror); the UK FCDO and EEAS statements to HRC63; MAS and MTI, *Consumer Price Developments in August 2026*; SP Group's tariff revisions; MOM's 2Q 2026 Labour Market Report; the FOMC statement, Summary of Economic Projections and press-conference transcript of 16 September; the Bank of Japan's decision of 18 September; BLS CPI; US DOL weekly claims; the US Treasury daily par and real yield-curve CSVs; EIA's Short-Term Energy Outlook and RBRTed.xls; ECDC and WHO on the Bundibugyo epidemic; CDC *MMWR* 75(35); GOV.UK's children's online-safety fact sheet; SFA on home-based food businesses; Meteorological Service Singapore; akorda.kz; muftyat.kz. **Peer-reviewed and preprint:** Landis et al., *eLife* (2021); Pérez-Alvarado et al., *Frontiers in Microbiology* (2022); Dinkelbach et al., *JCPP* (2026); Bläschke et al., *medRxiv* (2026); Lee et al., *JAMA Pediatrics* (2026); Stein et al., *IJBNA* (2026); Prince et al., *BJSM* (2026); Bagheri et al., *JISSN* (2026); Wiedemann et al., *Int. J. LCA* (2021); Naylor et al., *TRJ* (2014); Stevic et al., *PsyArXiv* (2026); Urinboyev et al., *Journal of Gambling Issues* (2025); Khamzina & Buribayev, *Frontiers in Sociology* and *Frontiers in Psychology* (2026). **Makers, vendors and platforms:** Apple Newsroom and Apple Singapore; Hugging Face model cards and file-tree APIs; GitHub (llama.cpp, vLLM); Artificial Analysis; TrendForce; Micron via GlobeNewswire; Google Patents; ficonTEC; gronefeld.com; Monochrome and Fratello; ridgemerino.com, woolandprince.com, icebreaker.com, minus33.com, nuyarn.com, suedwollegroup.com; brodandtaylor.com, sourhouse.co, lodgecastiron.com, challengerbreadware.com, rofco.be, thermoworks.com, wiremonkey.com; the Kallang, singaporegp.sg, nact.jp, mori.art.museum, sumo.pia.jp, snowfes.com, mplus.org.hk, ausopen.com. **Press, trade and community:** Al Jazeera, France 24 with AFP, Euronews, TIME, The Local, Nordkurier, CBS News, PBS NewsHour, Morocco World News, Heinrich-Böll-Stiftung; TechNode, ip fray, Tom's Hardware, MacStories, Engadget, The Standard (HK); Pitchfork, Variety, Box Office Mojo, The Numbers, Official Charts, Universal Music; Mothership, AsiaOne, Little Big Red Dot, Business Times, HardwareZone EDMW; Kursiv, Orda, SPIK.kz, Lada.kz, Tengrinews, Finprom.kz, youth.kz, Azattyq Ruhy, inbusiness.kz, Legalbet.kz; Hacker News (via its Algolia API), The Fresh Loaf, King Arthur Baking, Wordloaf, The Sourdough Journey, the Real Bread Campaign, MiddleClass, Eatbook, HungryGoWhere, The Ranting Panda, Pack Hacker. **Refused this build, and named for it:** Reuters, Bloomberg, AP, CNN, CNBC, SCMP, Straits Times, CNA, SingStat, mas.gov.sg, Reddit, Digtimes, bmj.com, bjsm.bmj.com, thelancet.com, esafety.gov.au, marinabaysands.com, ticketmaster.sg, Klook, Burpple, billboard.com, ohchr.org, adilet.zan.kz, gov.kz, upload.wikimedia.org (rate-limited). Nothing in this issue is attributed to any of them.